EXECUTIVE GUIDE TO
RELATIONSHIPS

Enhance romantic partnerships, friendships, and parent-child relationships

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Relationships Matter to Executives

As Extraverts, Executives love connecting with other people. They're drawn to active roles in traditional, respected institutions, such as civic organizations or faith communities. In their free time, they may find themselves nurturing these connections and participating in related events, from fundraisers to board meetings. These types hate to let people down, so they develop reputations for being straightforward and reliable, never skipping a meeting or flaking on a commitment at the last moment.

That said, they take care not to let their social responsibilities compromise their family life. Many Executives consider family among their top priorities and strive to ensure a stable, orderly life for their loved ones. Given their respect for all that's time-honored, they can also be trusted to carry on traditions from one generation to the next.

Practical and efficient, Executives aren't prone to grand gestures or great shows of affection. Instead, they show how much they care through acts of service. Rather than buying flowers or writing poems, they might take care of a loved one's car or clean the kitchen. What they lack in emotional expression, Executives make up for in consistency, loyalty, and devotion. They show up on time, deliver on their promises, and stand by the people who matter to them.

These qualities make people with this personality type invaluable to their families and friend groups. But Executives' traits can also, in some cases, hold them back in their relationships. They tend to struggle to recognize and honor their feelings, let alone those of others. Given their rational, concrete mindsets, they may be put off by the irrational and sometimes messy emotions that show up in relationships. To deepen and sustain their bond with others, they may need to learn to accept their feelings and respect other people's emotional needs.

In these pages, we'll discuss how Executives can bring the full range of their gifts to their relationships – including their romantic relationships, their friendships, and, if they have children, parenthood. We'll also discuss how Executives can honor their duties and traditional principles, without neglecting themselves or their loved ones. Along the way,

Executives will be equipped with insights and strategies to help them build thriving connections with others.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Romantic Relationships

Productivity and perseverance are common personal objectives for Executives. Romantic partners who respect these goals are needed for these types to feel happy in relationships. For them, tradition and security enable love to grow, and they want longevity. They're unabashed about their exacting requirements when establishing such commitments, though, and finding someone to love is a deliberate process for them.

However, it would be a mistake to oversimplify Executives' rational natures as cold or unloving. Status is very important to these individuals, and finding love falls within their broad social ambitions. Executives want others they can trust and share emotional connections that are so difficult for them to master on their own. Though outgoing by nature, being deeply connected to others isn't easy for them. They find that loving relationships enhance their lives by fulfilling a fundamental human need they might struggle with.

Executives' love comes not merely from emotion, but from a desire for advancement. When these types meet others who attractively reflect their values, they see them as components of more complete lives. They tend to be motivated and self-sufficient, but quickly find that lovers who complement them are major assets. Love brings a sense of stability that strengthens Executives' efforts in life – one way or another, having a partner moves these individuals forward.

They approach love confidently, and as a serious matter. While not fluent in subtle emotional understanding, they're dedicated once they

commit. These types don't appreciate those they see as unreliable, but they welcome into their lives people who impress them. When someone also meets Executives' deeper criteria and enters their hearts – which isn't an easy thing – they gain special status among all others.

Once real partnerships form, Executives work hard to make them prosper. This doesn't mean such relationships are invulnerable. They can still succumb to the things that destroy couples, especially if these types can't find a way to be sensitive, honest with their deeper feelings, and compromise their strict views. However, romantic relationships are unlikely to crumble because Executives fail to apply enough effort.

Dating and the Single Executive

If someone attracts Executives romantically, it's usually because they've had time to appreciate that person's qualities. "Love at first sight" can happen, but they often form a romantic interest in deliberate ways. They aren't reluctant to socialize, and are quite enthusiastic about branching out and meeting new people. Executives rarely let physical attraction overcome their strict standards, but once others catch their eye, they're unreserved in their pursuit.

These types prefer traditional dating practices, typically finding potential romantic partners in places where they first become acquainted with them casually, such as work, school, or meeting through mutual friends. Novelty isn't necessary – in fact, spontaneity may feel like a distraction to Executives when they're first getting to know someone. They strongly prefer planned activities where they can focus on a partner without a lot of surprises, and are usually the ones planning their dates.

Someone who is too spontaneous can disenchant Executives, who often interpret it as irresponsibility. These types are confident, but prefer structure and rules, and making emotional connections is hard enough for them without disorganization in the mix. Not everyone they date may embrace their strict codes, however, and Executives may repel or reject otherwise perfectly good romantic partners by judging this too harshly.

If they don't get past what they may initially see as someone's flaws, they miss the chance to know their admirable qualities, and a growing

relationship might end. Astute Executives quickly realize that pushing themselves to be more open-minded keeps them in the prime waters of the dating pool. However, if the pursuit of a potential mate consistently takes them outside their preferences, Executives can lose patience. Once they decide against something, they're often quick to remove it from their lives.

Executives in the Bedroom

To put it in perhaps unromantic terms, Executives' natural drive to do a good job extends to sex, as they're goal-oriented and focused. Their performance is somewhere in their consciousness during physical intimacy, as well as a sense of responsibility to their partners. Having strict personal boundaries, these types aren't particularly sensitive or open-minded in the bedroom, but ideally, they want to please their partners.

Their firmly resolved nature can create conflict if their beloveds show an interest in experimenting, as many do to keep their sex lives fresh. Depending on their background, they may have narrow personal definitions of acceptable sexual behavior. If this is the case, being pressured to be experimental can provoke sharp refusal from Executives.

Despite being very outspoken, it's rarely easy for Executives to understand and express their deeper feelings or vulnerabilities. Learning to communicate honestly and unreservedly about sexual matters is essential for them, and a wise priority to address early in sexual relationships.

Taking Failure to Heart

Executives like steady, predictable advancement in life, and breakups are assaults on those goals. They go against everything Executives prefer in relationships, and feel like personal failures. These individuals assume they should be able to repair a troubled romance with a calculated solution and vigorous effort, but logic and energy aren't always enough. They get frustrated when their direct approach doesn't gain traction in subtle matters of the heart.

When these types think they see an end coming, they may terminate a romance preemptively with unapologetic swiftness. It may seem callous, but they prefer to save themselves – and their sweethearts – from protracted pain. If there was ever a "rip the bandage off" type, its Executives. This is also an attempt to maintain control over their lives. Despite a sense of failure, they may judge it to be the best way to restore stability and progress. Even in love, their practical rationality wins out.

After breakups, Executives are wise to seek the company of friends and family. Social contact energizes them, and it helps remind them that a bad experience with one person doesn't diminish their ability to connect with someone else. Executives are more emotionally detached than most types, and a breakup can push these individuals into unbalanced states of cynicism and selfishness. However, that same emotional detachment allows Executives to see experiences for what they were in a balanced way, and avoid irrationally painting future romances with past frustrations.

Potential Role Pairings

Bold and decisive, Executives love to create structure, but people aren't like puzzle pieces that fit together consistently, nor can they be forced into alignment. Executives can relax their vigorous, exacting approach a little when pursuing love. Healthy relationships aren't tasks to be accomplished, and other people generally don't like to be controlled.

The Right Approach

While romance is far from an exact science, Executive lovers understand that putting their best feet forward achieves the best results. With so many personality variables in play, this often means proceeding into the unknown with an open mind, knowing that while they can't control other people's behavior, maintaining a balanced, positive, and accepting attitude brings out the best in others.

The information presented here can help Executives build and navigate successful relationships. Knowledge of other personality tendencies enables Executives to do what they do best: decide and execute. These types excel at working toward success, and since true love is unlikely to

be found in a perfect package, they must correspondingly work toward some flexibility of mind if they want to succeed.

With this in mind, we'll offer a helpful look at some of the ways Executives and other types are likely to interact, and insight to help them maximize their chances for happiness by creating fulfilling and balanced relationships with those types.

Executive-Analyst Relationships

Executives and Analysts both approach finding partners with some degree of calculation. On some level, most people employ a mental checklist when they meet potential romantic candidates, but for these types, those checklists are more deliberate and conscious. This systematic approach reflects their rational way of avoiding expected problems, and is helpful if not taken too far or relied on entirely.

Balanced Executive-Analyst Relationships

A Romantic Mental Checklist

Executives' checklist involves strict standards, personal traditions, and the desire to craft stable lives, while Analysts have extremely specific likes and dislikes based on their ideas and ideals. Neither are likely to be unsure of their preferences, and both approach relationships with a sense of mental negotiation. Honestly communicating the "must-haves" on their respective checklists sets up foundations that increase their potential to build mutually satisfying love.

Effective Together

Although they might express it differently, both partner types in these couples appreciate efficiency and accomplishment. For Executives, it's real-world and practical – they like things hassle-free and secure, and have the energy to ensure these preferences. For Analysts, it concerns more theoretical ideas about progress and improvement. They enjoy finding innovative and unconventional procedures that wring the greatest benefit out of life, albeit it's sometimes complicated. If these lovers tap into each other's strengths, they make formidable couples.

Executives are impressed by Analysts' penchant for solving life's puzzles – if it's not overdone. They find Analysts' optimal solutions to be highly useful, and Executives appreciate little more than usefulness. In return, Analysts find a helpful dose of realism in Executives' cool, decisive rationality. The fact that they don't get lost in ideas stabilizes ever-imaginative Analysts, something especially needed by those with the Prospecting trait.

Both these types enjoy longevity in relationships. Executives want reliable partners that create a sense of continuity, and Analysts, ever logical, fulfill this need. In turn, Analysts find that having sensible, energetic Executive sweethearts as constants in their lives allows them to focus on bigger issues. These two types agree that drama and chaos aren't good uses of energy, and finding others to love who make sense to them is rare for both, so they treasure the accomplishment.

Unbalanced Executive-Analyst Relationships

Competing Priorities

When Executives want traditional approaches, and Analysts want to re-engineer everything, it can lead to frustration. Their sense of satisfaction comes from different things: Executives find satisfaction in being anchored and accomplishing specific goals, and Analysts find it in exploring ideas and working on ever-evolving projects.

Executives quickly lose patience with Analyst lovers always engaging myriad possibilities in an unbalanced manner. If Analysts insist on perpetually experimenting, or worse, spending time and energy on

ideas that go nowhere, Executives become irritated. These types invest heavily in keeping their day-to-day lives in order, and individuals can easily become overly critical in an unbalanced way when Analysts lose themselves in ideas that seem irrelevant to daily life.

Unfortunately, Analysts are deeply hurt when Executives dismiss matters they care about. For Analysts, trying to master larger concepts is important, and having their inspiration marginalized is a serious affront. Analysts can argue for their ideas well beyond the balanced boundaries of logic, and being dismissed out of hand only inflames them further. Arguments of principle versus practicality can quickly get out of hand, causing serious damage to their relationships.

Active Minds, Closed Hearts

Both Executives and Analysts tend to live through rationality, and they very likely experience a "meeting of the minds" that draws them together initially. While this can lead to a spark of something deeper, both types often have difficulty establishing or maintaining emotional connections. Executives and Analysts can have unbalanced, yet functional lives together – even sexual relationships – and yet markedly lack intimacy and emotional openness. Talking about their feelings might seem confusing or unimportant to types who prize logic, and Executives and Analysts may even see discussing feelings as some kind of admission of personal weakness.

In ongoing love affairs, this is likely to become a problem. Executives and Analysts have plenty of emotions, and when discomfort with those emotions prevents them from expressing their feelings, they can't effectively resolve unbalanced issues. The frustration that even healthy, loving people occasionally feel with each other quickly becomes dangerous when ignored or suppressed. Both types tend to focus on fixing apparent problems with a rational approach, leaving inner emotional issues continually festering.

A lack of emotional openness doesn't just harm Executive-Analyst couples' ability to work through problems – it tragically decreases some of the most rewarding things that loving couples can share together: warmth, reassurance, joy, childish excitement, tenderness, and physical affection. Such things are rarely foremost in either type's mind, but they

appreciate them just the same. In unbalanced relationships, a lack of emphasis on these intimate behaviors diminishes the quality of life for these lovers, and gradually diminishes the spark between them as well.

Rebalancing Executive-Analyst Relationships

Respecting the Needs of the Moment and the Future

Executives can respectfully point out to their Analyst partners that constant exploring and experimenting not only bothers them, but it also consumes significant resources within their relationships such as time, attention, and personal energy. Analysts can remind themselves of their responsibility to manage their shared resources, even intangible ones, in a way that's acceptable to both types. This means reigning in their imaginations now and then to focus on present needs in their lives. They can show respect for their Executive partners by turning some of their creative energy toward the major long-term advancement of their relationships, as well as new ideas.

In turn, Executives can practice giving Analysts some respectful latitude. Analysts can't be happy ignoring problems or ideas, and are compelled to innovate, sometimes learning much by creative failure. When Analysts demonstrate responsible contributions to their relationships, they also earn the right to put time and energy into their ideas and projects, no matter what anyone else thinks about the merits. However, just because wise Executives indulge Analysts' intellectual exercises, it doesn't mean they need to participate or hear about them constantly.

Cooperation, Together or Individually

These couples can agree to manage certain aspects of their shared lives independently. For example, forward-thinking and imaginative Analysts could take the lead in finding clever investments or shopping for deals on big purchases. Any area where new or changing information must be evaluated appeals to their ability to explore and optimize. In turn, Executives can organize and manage everyday matters like ensuring bills are paid on time, and their schedules are kept, assuring the stability of their shared lives.

These lovers may simply also have to compromise at times. These types are smart to model their differing perspectives not as arguments, but as rational proposals. Whether pushing for change or tradition, each must prove the benefits of their method to the other. It logically follows that each type must also stay open to the other's ideas. Writing out benefits and costs can help Executive-Analyst couples discuss compromises reasonably. Rather than wasting time endlessly debating, a little hands-on demonstration with an open mind can also efficiently help them decide what works best.

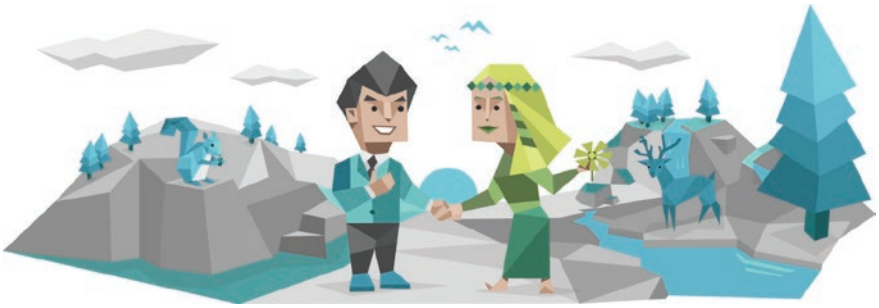
Keeping the Spark Alive

Emotional honesty is often hard for Executives, who want to simply force life to cooperate without a lot of introspection. Emotional candor may feel like weakness to them, as if exposing any vulnerability invites chaos. Analysts are similarly reluctant, relatively ignorant about their inner emotions or those of others despite their active imaginations. However, Executives and Analysts seeking to rebalance a lack of intimacy must be open about their needs and feelings. This can start simply enough with sharing their emotional states with their partners on a regular basis. Instead of just discussing facts, partners can make a point of saying how they feel. Here are some ways these couples can broach the subject.

- Saying, "I feel angry at what was just said," is a fair way to give partners an opportunity to make immediate amends before problems deepen.
- Or, if one arrives home from work stressed and frustrated, they can say so, and their partner can offer support: "You do sound frustrated, want to talk about it?"
- These types naturally fall into problem-solving together, but making a conscious effort to also take care of each other on an emotional level helps keep their sense of intimacy alive.
- Resolving issues with each other is important, but it's just as critical for these types to share positive emotions and experiences with each other. When one is feeling happy or appreciative of the other, it's important to take the time to express it clearly.

- Improving intimacy isn't just about supporting each other through challenges, it's also about sharing pleasurable, easy, and satisfying moments in life together. Whether it's cooking a special meal on a Friday night, celebrating a professional triumph, or sharing a cozy massage, participating in the sweeter parts of life alongside each other affirms strong, loving relationships. For Executives and Analysts alike, it may take some conscious effort to focus on these sentimental intangibles, but the gains are tremendous.

Executive-Diplomat Relationships



Executives and Diplomats aren't always easy romantic pairings, but while having a great many differences, they share the ideal of dedication to the ones they love. Diplomats feel their loved ones' emotional states as if they were their own, wanting to support their partners' growth and happiness. Executives stride forward in life, seeking to create a secure, prosperous environment for themselves and those they love. Even though they develop their standards in different ways, both strive to be instrumental in creating harmony.

Balanced Executive-Diplomat Relationships

Dedicated Couples

While Executives may not be overt with their feelings, they can give Diplomats the steady support they need make functional progress. When Diplomats get lost in their imagination or worry about what might happen, Executives pull them back to the good things that already exist between them.

In return, Diplomats remind Executives that they can be loved for themselves, and not just what they accomplish. Executives put a lot of pressure on themselves to succeed and be recognized. Diplomats recognize them for who they are, putting the well-being and happiness of their sweethearts above any material successes. To Diplomats, the strengths and virtues of Executives' character are just as worthy of praise as their accomplishments. This might seem revolutionary to these practical types, but it feels wonderful. Executives derive deep security from the fact that they needn't be always perfect to receive the warm devotion of their Diplomat lovers.

Dreams and Reality in Balance

Executives' emphasis on practical accomplishment is the perfect supplement to Diplomats' focus on intangible development. Diplomats are inspired dreamers, and Executives offer a pragmatic hand that counterbalances their airy ideas. Where Diplomats might avoid life's mundane details in favor of dreams, Executives help them power through everyday responsibilities. Ultimately, Diplomats find this helps make their dreams a reality, and love their Executive partners even more for helping them grow.

Diplomats, in turn, try to help Executives grow beyond mundane routine. Executives are highly goal-oriented, but the ambitiousness of those goals can be limited by their focus on convention. Diplomats lovingly show them an expanded view of their potential, inspiring Executives to new levels of success. Where Executives might revel in achieving a high management position, Diplomats might ask, "Why not start your own company, babe?" Through the supportive, idealistic love of Diplomats, Executives discover exciting goals that they might not conceive on their own, yet are within their reach.

Strong, Distinct Values

While they may arrive at their values very differently, these are both values-based types. Executives settle on strict, tradition-oriented values through experience and logic. Diplomats form values through philosophical exploration and a deep empathetic connection to all life. Executive-Diplomat couples respect that they both embrace balanced personal codes because they truly believe they're the best way to live their lives.

These couples can refine and update each other's values. Executives may be so focused on personal achievement that they fail to consider the advantages of integration, dismissing anyone who doesn't share their exact values. Diplomats are all about universal harmony, though, and can help Executives develop their personal status in balanced ways that connect to progressive, diverse, modern values – more open doors mean more opportunities to advance.

On the flip side, Diplomats focus so broadly on moral and idealistic values that their own lives often suffer. Executive lovers remind Diplomats that achieving great things for themselves builds a strong foundation to express their dreams for the world. Prosperity and personal power aren't sins against humanity, and Executives' values empower Diplomats beautifully. When these types each take a page from the other's book of values, they're better off for it. Executives who are connected to their humanity easily achieve noble status, and Diplomats with the tools to focus and bring their ideas into reality are a benefit to the world.

Unbalanced Executive-Diplomat Relationships

The Practical Clashes with the Ideal

Executives and Diplomats loving each other is a wonderful thing, but these partnerships don't always unfold in balance. At first, Executives find that Diplomats' focus on ideals appeals to their sense of rightness – they honor their tradition-based values just as strongly. However, once the novelty wears off, they may wonder how practical Diplomats are, and if they can turn talk into results. Diplomats, meanwhile, may begin to feel that Executives lack imagination, and wonder how such partners can truly understand what matters to them.

Executives want their sweethearts to become more grounded with time, as achieving stable and prosperous lives together is always on their minds. However, Diplomats often embrace continuous change rather than settling down. Their grand visions for the future can seem to belittle the more realistic goals Executives work so hard for, baffling these determined, practical types. For Executives, everything worthwhile happens because someone dutifully follows a planned

course of action, something easily lost to Diplomats' focus on things like politics, social justice, or personal creativity. Often struggling to follow through on their big ideas, Diplomats can just as easily forget to buy milk on the way home. Executives can be unforgiving of this kind of failure, even in minor matters.

Executives are unlikely to see Diplomats' grand-scale worries and dreams as pertinent to their shared welfare. They perhaps can even see them as risks. These types tend to be realistic about their concerns, and after a cursory appreciation of Diplomats' perspective, they may reject all the "what ifs" as an inefficient waste of time and energy – nothing realistically actionable. Diplomats can be hurt by this curt appraisal, often considering their open-ended thinking loftily superior, and may allow this pain to deepen into unbalanced contempt for partners who "don't get" their high-mindedness.

When Emotions Confuse

Diplomats are far freer with their emotions than Executives, who prefer to control or even hide their feelings. They may be in similar emotional states, but their styles and degrees of expression are quite distinct. Diplomats' freer feelings are often quite confusing and troubling for Executives, who almost always prefer controlled steadiness over openly expressed emotions. Likewise, Diplomats are confused by Executives' refusal to emote, often worrying that it's somehow a reflection on them. Consequently, Diplomats may try to force Executives' feelings out, becoming even more upset if they can't. Executives' responses are likely to be something unbalanced and unsympathetically practical along the lines of, "Get over it."

Executives don't enjoy exposure to strong emotions, even by someone they love. They may regard too much emotion – even their own – as weakness or self-indulgence, and may respond in an unbalanced, callous way. Even worse, if emotional pressure continues unchecked, it can begin to feel like a threat to the stability of their lives. They may create distance as a form of self-defense, and Diplomats sense this with dismay, further widening the gap. This is absolute poison to loving relationships, so bringing emotional communication into balance is of critical importance for these couples.

Rebalancing Executive-Diplomat Relationships

Open-Minded Dedication

Executives aren't known for open-mindedly embracing change. Similarly, Diplomats frequently ignore facts that contradict their ideals. For such couples, it goes beyond, "We should do this," versus "We should do that." Balance starts with respectful compromise, but also includes being truly open to each other's points of view. Appreciating that contributions to their relationships need not be similar to be valuable requires both these types to loosen their strict priorities and consider each other's very different needs and virtues.

What this looks like on a day-to-day basis is asking how they can support each other, expressing their needs honestly, and making a sincere effort to do whatever it takes to make their time together happy, yet functional. In specific terms, Executives must patiently acknowledge that Diplomats have a right to their less tangible concerns and interests, even if they seem wildly impractical. If there's one thing that Executives understand, it's the transactional nature of achievement, and achieving fair and mutually fulfilling romantic relationships requires that they invest hard work, just like any worthy goal. Here are some tips these couples can take to heart.

- Whether it means attending a political rally, taking a painting class, or learning to meditate, Executives can understand that sincerely engaging in things outside their norm are ways to make fair contributions to happy lives together with Diplomats.
- These practical types may also be surprised to find their interests expanded – everything they love was also new to them at one point, and Executives are rarely shy about engaging opportunities.
- If they can't find any enjoyment in one thing, they can try something else, as it's the effort and openness that Diplomats appreciate.

In turn, Diplomats can understand the limits of their Executive partners: they can only handle so much novelty and mystical openness without rolling their eyes.

Respecting Everyday Goals

In balanced relationships, Executives' need for order, practicality, and advancement in life aren't only respected, they're supported. This requires Diplomats to sometimes focus their energy on mundane goals and methods instead of grand ideals. If they're not always taking an equal role in day-to-day responsibilities, Diplomats can at least allow Executives to handle those things their own way. Diplomats can be grateful to have lovers as rational, decisive, and dauntless as Executives planning workable paths forward for their lives together.

Some days, instead of trying to push Executives to do something fun and inspired, Diplomats can roll up their sleeves and join their partners in the routine trenches of everyday life. This might mean mowing the lawn, deciding on a new investment, or simply providing Executives with lunch and support while they figure things out. Working hard on the practical priorities of the moment is a challenge for Diplomats, but love for their sweethearts gives them a reason to try. A stable foundation and progressive direction are both possible when these couples balance their time, thoughts, and energy between ideal possibilities and current responsibilities. It's not easy, but the results of such balance are stunning.

Emotion and Logic in Proportion

Glorious potentials aside, reconciling Executive-Diplomat couples' respective tendencies to function through either logic or emotion is an ongoing challenge. It's critical that each type recalibrate their expectations of the other – frustration happens when expectations are out of touch with reality. Executives get out of touch by having unforgivingly strict standards, and Diplomats by having hopelessly imaginative ideals. However, Executives can't reasonably expect Diplomat partners to be coolly sensible all the time, nor can Diplomats reasonably expect constant emotional sensitivity from Executives.

With realistic expectations in mind, these partners can respect each other's unique ways of expressing themselves. Executives rarely give Diplomats the lush, emotional feedback they crave, but they express their love and commitment through sincere dedication and tireless effort. Diplomats can appreciate the way their Executive partners enhance their shared lives with prosperity and security.

In turn, Executives understand that loving relationships include profound and honest emotional connections. Diplomats can encourage them toward further openness by ensuring that sharing emotions is a non-volatile experience. Both these types grow as individuals and build stronger relationships by imitating qualities of the other. Executives can work to explore and share their own emotions, and Diplomats can practice judicious self-control of emotion.

In everyday terms, Executives can make themselves talk about what they feel, and Diplomats can pause to really think before sharing. Both types can also take a hard look together at the chain of events that led to any emotional issues between them. Talking it through step by step gives them a chance to spot false assumptions, explain themselves, and clear the air of overreaction. Making efforts to bridge each other's level of emotionality doesn't mean sacrificing their unique natures, but it allows these types to come together with true understanding and honesty.

Executive-Sentinel Relationships

Couples sharing many core traits have an easier time understanding each other, so these pairings are often comfortable matches. Relationships between Executives and other Sentinels thrive on their sense of duty, commitment, and mutual constancy. While the specifics may differ, each understands the other's desire to build useful foundations and maintain the traditions that define their worlds. They both appreciate a clear path forward, and try to proceed sensibly and smoothly without complicating things. Diligence might be the first quality they notice and admire about each other, beyond initial physical attraction.

Balanced Executive-Sentinel Relationships

Consistency

From the moment they decide to commit, things are quite serious between Executives and other Sentinels in love. Both types feel a strong pull toward stabilizing things. They both like to focus on building better, more secure lives, and having significant others with the same goals satisfyingly reinforces their momentum. When they feel sure of their lovers being "the one," plans are made in clear terms and engaged briskly. When two Sentinel types merge, genuinely responsible mutual caretaking can develop that's unsurpassed by other personality types.

Sharing a Down-to-Earth Approach

Executives love Sentinels for their hands-on practicality. Together, they embrace established wisdom and understanding rather than conjured theoretical musings. That's not to say their relationships are devoid of imagination, but they find that putting their energy into practical matters and proven methods tends to be more productive. Their sensible attention to immediate needs assures them that their lives can improve steadily. When they dream of a better future, it usually happens, as they embrace reasonable, achievable goals.

Unlike those who feel rewarded by dreaming itself, these couples feel a sense of purposeful satisfaction when they accomplish practical goals for themselves. They may have differing ways of engaging the world, but their respective approaches lead to the same destination. These couples work well together from an early stage, with Executives contributing a vigorous, logical sensibility and Sentinels adding their own unique forms of prudence and perseverance. They have little trouble seeing each other's functional virtues, so fairness and cooperation are likely within these love affairs.

Comfort with Differences

Because Executives and other Sentinels share some key ways of approaching life, balancing other trait differences is also more approachable. For example, Executives in love with Consuls can comfortably enjoy the warmer side of social experiences. Their partners' energy and boldness match their own, but with added levels of empathy and charisma right at the surface.

Romances with Consuls or Defenders give Executives chances to connect through emotions while respecting their focus on convention. Where Diplomats might try to pull them too far afield, these Sentinels draw them close into reassuring, loving nests, with Defenders especially placing great importance on their private lives as couples. Within the personal traditions they build with these types, Executives find it easy to open their hearts, relax their logic, and grow in balanced ways.

When paired with Logistician partners, Executives may begin to see the virtues of reserved contemplation versus swift action. While both types tend to be logical and sensible, Logisticians place even more value on carefully making the right decision, and aren't afraid to take the time to do so. Their caution is a good balancing element for Executives' often brash, forceful manner when confronted by life's challenges.

Unbalanced Executive-Sentinel Relationships

Too Much of a Good Thing

When individuals with similar traits fall in love, such combinations can also result in too much of a good thing. Even tradition-bound Sentinels pass through stages of change, and may become bored or frustrated with the very routines that once made them happy. There's a difference between satisfaction and joy, and these types may become so focused on stability that joy drains from their lives, leaving only predictable routines in its place.

Not only may these couples find that satisfaction alone eventually becomes insufficient, but the danger is even worse if both Executives and other Sentinel lovers don't share the sense of stagnation. When one type questions the direction or quality of their life and begins to desire change, and the other doesn't, it can feel like an abandonment of everything they've built together. Judgmental and bold, Executives may be especially unforgiving in unbalanced relationships, regardless of which side they're on. They don't take kindly to those who threaten the desired course of their lives, and if their partners push too strongly for change or try to hold them in unhappy routines, Executives can forcefully resist in unbalanced ways.

Missed Opportunities

Even if they never disagree on aspects of their lives together, such couples may become insulated inside the worlds they know. Executive-Sentinel couples in unbalanced relationships don't pay much attention to anything outside of those spaces, possibly ignoring highly beneficial opportunities that seem too risky. When they reinforce each other's reliance on the status quo, these significant others never discover their options, much less reach out to them. Executives are far from immune – while they don't hesitate to surge toward their goals, those goals often show a lack of broader vision. All their energy and willpower doesn't guarantee awareness or acceptance of new potentials, especially if their Sentinel partners are also focused only on what's already known.

Personal growth, success, and prosperity almost always entail a measure of risk. However, Executive-Sentinel partners in unbalanced relationships support each other's security rather than growth. Trying new paths may seem pointless when a perfectly good situation already exists – especially one they worked so hard to create together. If these types reassure each other that change isn't needed, they hold each other back. Worse, they may dislike change so much that they deliberately ignore circumstances that desperately need improvement.

Certainty or Tyranny?

The Judging trait inevitably contains a degree of certainty, an intrinsic way of thinking for both partners in Executive-Sentinel relationships. However, this in no way assures common preferences between the pair – one may like chocolate, the other, vanilla. The only thing they may agree on is wanting it their own way. Once Executives decide something is correct, they expect to move forward with it, and their blustery, autonomous decision-making can rankle their lovers.

Executives can be too pushy, but it may not occur to either of these types to ask their partners before making "obvious" choices if they're sure they're proceeding correctly. Such unbalanced high-handedness, even with the best of intentions, can be very damaging to their Sentinel lovers' sense of worth. Controlling behavior is truly the dark side of willfulness, and is the opposite of the practical compromise that all Sentinels embrace in balanced relationships. When one type

dominatingly overshadows decisions, long-term happiness can't prosper because freedom isn't shared.

Rebalancing Executive-Sentinel Relationships

Venturing into Something New Together

Individuals in balanced relationships undertake necessary adaptive behavior to get through life successfully. In this spirit, Executive-Sentinel couples can shake things up occasionally to find new opportunities and joy. Improvement is, by definition, a type of change, and must be sought consciously. A foray outside their routines is the first step to their achieving greater prosperity, strength, and happiness within their relationships. Fortunately, once these determined types engage something together, that decision alone provides shared motivation, as neither type commits lightly or gives up easily.

The key is in agreeing together to make an ongoing effort to expand. Emphasizing accepting new things into their lives cures notable flaws in these romances, such as stagnation and narrow vision. Partners in Executive-Sentinel couples might periodically ask themselves, "How can I improve my life?" and then ask their lovers to join them in testing the waters, be it trying a new restaurant, taking academic or recreational classes, or even researching and planning major things like a new career. Contemplating and engaging changes together takes much of the trepidation out of the experience, as these partners have each other's reliable support.

Compromise Is Necessary

The Judging trait, with all its certitude, doesn't have to serve as a lock on the mind. When it does, however, the heart provides the key. When these couples disagree, they must remind themselves of the deep appreciation they feel for each other's presence in their lives. The love they share motivates compromise. Fairly supporting each other's preferences doesn't require either type to change their own, just that they trade off supporting what the other prefers, some of the time. The following are some things these couples can keep in mind.

- Executives can make a special effort to support their Sentinel partners' needs and desires. They almost reflexively enforce their own views and methods, and while this may sometimes enhance practical aspects of life, it has no place when it comes to matters of personal preference.
- No matter how certain Executives are that pumpkin is the proper type of pie at the holidays, their partners' tastes deserve respectful inclusion, not dismissal. To do any less is to say their partners aren't equally worthy, and won't allow balanced relationships to prosper.

Always with an eye on their chosen goal, Executives place the success of their romances above differences within their balanced relationships, and give as much as they get.

Executive-Explorer Relationships

Executive-Explorer couples are frequently an odd combination, but such pairings can be quite serviceable for both. As Observant types, both tend to be hands-on and present-minded, but in different ways. Executives manage matters at hand responsibly to assure long-term success, living in the present but planning for a stable future. They consider consequences and then act decisively. Contrarily, Explorers regard every moment as an opportunity for immediate satisfaction or accomplishment, and future concerns aren't as important to them. This allows them to be flexible, and they're often able to get around restrictions to achieve their goals. This is helpful, as those goals are likely to change often.

Balanced Executive-Explorer Relationships

Opposites Do Attract

Opposites do attract. In fact, being vastly different can generate wonderful relationships because it offers balance. Attraction between Executives and Explorers sometimes happens because wise Executives realize they could use some unconventional inspiration to help them meet their goals. Explorers bring plenty of that, often spontaneously attacking and completing tasks that interest them. Executives find such fresh, effective productivity very attractive, indeed, and can jump in with Explorers, bringing their own energy to the party. On the other hand, when Explorers tire of the practical difficulties of living spontaneously, Executives may seem like a very appealing stabilizing element. Executives offer support that keeps Explorers' lives functioning, which ultimately enhances their ability to explore.

Completing Each Other

Executives tend to create a secure space for themselves that's tightly defined and all about functional and efficient order. Being alone in that safe, stable world can make their lives dull, though. Adding Explorers to their lives is a way of creating unexpected opportunities that cure dull routines. Explorers bring options aplenty, and Executives can maintain their energetic common sense while gathering knowledge through diverse hands-on experiences with these lively lovers.

When Executives and Explorers combine their lives, it can result in very real and satisfying unions. There may be some utilitarian symmetry in such relationships, but these types can learn a lot from each other. They can each give essential, but very different, kinds of support that help them both mature and grow. In balanced romances, Explorers' curiosity amends their partners' rigidity, and Executives' judiciousness tempers their sweethearts' exuberance.

How Executives find rewarding relationships with Explorers varies as much as Explorers themselves. Adventurers and Entertainers offer attentive sensitivity, with the former always conceiving new ways that these couples can engage life together, and the latter offering active social lives that appeal to Executives' ambition.

Being capable and attaining goals is something Executives respect, and Virtuosos' focus on mastering specific areas of skill is just such a quality. Likewise, the gainful effectiveness of Executive-Entrepreneur couples is amazing; they might build empires for themselves. If Executive-Explorer couples regard their differences as beneficial counter-balancing assets and maintain a healthy degree of tolerance, they can create outstanding bonds and much success together.

Unbalanced Executive-Explorer Relationships

Roles That Grow Old

Differences can bring about balance, but Executives and Explorers can also easily fall into roles with each other that become so distinct and repetitious that they create separation instead of unity. Executives tend to take on roles of organizing, planning, and meeting obligations, and Explorers are likely to be the more unrestrained, fun-loving members of these duos. These roles can work well when each feels the benefits of the other's approach, but quickly grow tiresome and oppressive if taken too far.

If these couples aren't careful, their relationships might start to resemble that of parents and children. It's burdensome for Executives to take all the responsibility while Explorers enjoy a carefree existence, and Explorers resent being controlled by rules they don't understand the need for. Executives aren't likely to be patient with this imbalance for long, so these patterns can become severely problematic if unaddressed.

Stability and Spontaneity in Conflict

Executives are usually deliberately set in their ways, while Explorers adapt their opinions or interests easily. This arrangement can easily frustrate Executives' need for a sense of reliability in their partners. In turn, Explorers may see their beloveds' unwillingness to change as a hindrance to their free expression. Explorers are independent and have a great deal of difficulty with commitments that they find confining. They rankle at rules and direction, two fundamental things to Executives' way of thinking.

In contrast, rules help make Executives comfortable, and in their relationships, they're likely to insist on defining commitment early on. Unfortunately, Explorers' independence often makes them resist signing on to a committed lifestyle, at least right away. They can demonstrate great longevity in love, but not if stressed with too many strict demands, as that kind of pressure just pushes them away. If one type seeks commitment while the other yearns for freedom, the early stages of any romance proceeds with great difficulty.

Rebalancing Executive-Explorer Relationships

Respectful Communication

The key to balancing tiresome relationship roles is viewing the issue as a matter of respect. Executives can respect themselves enough to reject the burden of being solely responsible in their households. If they're playing the "parents" too often, it's time for a talk – again, with respect playing a starring role. There's nothing wrong with saying, "I'm super stressed and busy, can you do a load of laundry to help me out?" When Explorers expand their participation in responsibilities, they can also create freedom for themselves, as balanced contributions create a solid sense of being equals.

Respect goes both ways in balanced relationships. Executives can remember that they fell in love with someone who has a higher tolerance for disorder and a lower tolerance for mundane activity. When the dishes need doing, Explorers' attention may be elsewhere, but finding ways to make such mundane things more exciting helps these couples get them done together. A little music and wine can sweeten a household chore into a more pleasant shared experience. In loving relationships, nobody should confuse encouraging more responsibility with demanding it, but both types must participate.

Benefitting from Each Other's Ways

Compromise is crucial to finding a workable way past differences, and drawing lines that are too firm is counterproductive. Below are some tips these twosomes can try.

- Explorers' flexible mindset can be a useful inspiration in this area. When Executives borrow just a little of their partners' open-minded outlook while relying on their natural ability to organize practically, solutions that make sense to both quickly appear.
- Rather than trying to push Explorers uncomfortably into detailed planning, Executives can reveal each part of a plan in sequence, allowing Explorers to focus more easily on what's in front of them. This also creates a sense of spontaneity that helps Explorers engage naturally.
- Likewise, when Explorers realize they need to step up their contributions to the functional parts of their relationships, they can borrow their Executive lovers' dutiful mindset.

However, the good news for Explorers is that they needn't force themselves into the rigid, organized way of thinking natural to Executives – their partners already have a firm enough sense of priorities and responsibilities. All they need to do is willingly bring their natural energy, adaptable minds, and capable hands to the party. Chances are, Executives can provide some productive, sensible ideas of where Explorers can put these great virtues to excellent use.

Conclusion

Embracing Possibilities

While they tend to be highly effective people on their own, relationships present Executives with wonderful opportunities to grow. Normally, these types feel little pull to open their mind to unplanned change, but love can give them powerful motivation to advance beyond their limits and habits. Partners in balanced relationships don't expect this to happen overnight, but for their part, Executives can push themselves out of a rut, appreciating inspiration and guidance from romantic partners they love and trust.

Executives who give themselves permission to intimately embrace their lovers' differences are likely to find more joy than they have ever experienced. All they need is a willingness to relax and be open – they can maintain their common sense and drive. Releasing themselves from certain routines may be a little destabilizing at first, but the rewards are

tremendous. Executives find their worlds brightened and their minds inspired by loving people with different perspectives.

These types seek to create trust, stability, and successful living – and they're willing to share. While this kind of firm foundation isn't always sought by every type, it's a pleasant surprise when it's discovered. Executives offer lovers support and security that allow them to reach higher and do more than they could on their own. When initial chemistry is followed up by ongoing tolerance and honesty, there's no reason why Executives can't enjoy lasting and balanced love with any personality type.

Friendships

Earning Executives' friendship isn't quick or easy – people with this personality type are vigorously exacting, and prefer to connect through standard practices and values more than ideas and feelings. Most of their friends are made not through random encounters, but through consistent contact, such as in class or in the workplace, where they've got the time to get to know and admire each other. These types like to see people's merits proven before granting them their friendship.

High Standards

What makes Executives' friendships grow is the mutual respect and trust that comrades give each other. Functionality and stability are paramount to these types, and friends who reflect these qualities are valuable assets in their lives. They rarely find the orderly predictability they seek in other people, so they especially appreciate friends who are reliable. Executives crave a world where people are responsible, trustworthy, and capable – friendships that offer these values satisfy them deeply.

Comfortable with Detachment

Executives give an energetic form of friendship that revolves around shared commonality, but not much emotional intimacy. They take a brisk, no-nonsense approach to life, and aren't given to social softness or warmth. Trusted friends are useful bridges in this area, showing people with this personality type the direct value of deeper human connection. Through friendship, Executives balance their somewhat brusque outlook with the practical benefits of having good people around.

While they tend to be socially outgoing, these types don't need friendship to feel secure. Executives find people's overt emotions tedious, often disdaining sensitive or inconsistent people, and they're quite comfortable on their own. So, when they do find others who seem worthy, the favor they grant in the form of friendship is significant. If these people disappoint, however, Executives become dismissive – they don't easily give second chances.

Strong as Stone

An uncompromising nature is just one side of the Executive social coin, as their resolute core also provides them with appealing fortitude and energy. They're always ready to use their tireless diligence and intelligence to help their true friends come up with thoughtful solutions. Vigorous, practical, and principled, Executives make excellent friends, if their camaraderie can be won in the first place.

Where Executives' rigidity can hold them back socially is their unwillingness to try new things. They aren't easily intimidated, but also aren't easily impressed or enthused by unproven possibilities. However, Executives do step outside their boundaries if given a substantial reason, and good friends draw them into new things by demonstrating the benefits. When these types deem others worthy as friends, they also value their judgment, and this opens them up to sampling the unknown.

Commonality and Community

Executives' desire for stability and status is reflected by their social choices, as they like being around those who respect their values and culture. Friendships are likely to flourish in environments that reflect what they've decided on through their own experiences. Of course, what's compatible depends on their personal history as individuals – the only sure thing that they're very specific about is their beliefs.

Executives are socially outgoing in whatever community feels like home, but rarely feel pulled to explore other ways of life. But those seeking to diversify their friendships wisely look for groups formed around common subjects and pursuits, from gardening to gaming to sports. This is an easy way for these types to get to know and better understand people with different views and backgrounds. Sharing an interest means agreeing on at least that one thing.

Pleasant Surprises

Executives' exceedingly specific social preferences don't prevent them from building friendships with very different types of people – those people just need to impress them consistently. If there's one thing Executives appreciate, it's finding others who are reliable and capable. These types can't help but respect extremely effective individuals, regardless of how they operate, and it's even better if they also prove to be personally trustworthy.

Executives and Friends of Other Types

Executives can enjoy friendship with almost anyone who meets such essential standards. We'll look at some of the virtues that these types can share with each Role group through friendship, as well as some areas of potential difficulty. Most importantly, we'll also go over some helpful things Executives can do to make friendships work with other personality types.

Executive-Analyst Friendships

Executive-Analyst friendships form easily, as these types have a lot in common. However, the headstrong, often confrontational nature of Commanders and Debaters can challenge Executives' patience. Luckily, Executives are bold enough to match the energetic willpower of these types, and can firmly offer some sensible advice when they get too carried away. These Analysts, in turn, respect Executives' strength of character and admire their steady, level-headed ability. When Executives befriend them, they, in turn, gain gutsy, creative allies to help them overcome life's toughest problems, making for nearly unlimited possible success.

Balanced Executive-Analyst Friendships

Support and Assistance

Not all Analyst friends are so challenging to be around, though. Executives appreciate Logicians' and Architects' quiet, thoughtful natures. They see how these types take the time to figure out ingenious solutions and find their input helpful on nearly everything. It may not always be easy to understand their curious musings, but their calculated ideas appeal to Executives' sense of logic. Analysts' ingenuity bolsters their ideas, and in return, they offer such friends practical steps to help convert their creative thoughts into active plans.

Freedom to Say What They Think

Executives and Analysts share a common problem: they aren't very sensitive to people's feelings, and sometimes use inconsiderate, direct ways of communicating. When dealing with other personality types, this often results in conversational *faux pas*, forcing them to reverse course and confusedly apologize to keep the peace. Constantly having to adjust their words so that they don't offend more fragile people is frustrating – it's as if they're always on a leash and can't be themselves.

In the company of Analysts, however, Executives find incredible freedom of speech. They may be asked to explain their ideas and opinions, but they won't need to apologize for the way they voice them. These types can relax and speak their truest, harshest views of the world together with little chance of bruised egos and hurt feelings. Compared to their attempts to get along with more sensitive personality types, this can feel like a relief. Executives find a dynamic conversational playground among Analyst friends, who are always happy to hear their honest thoughts.

Unbalanced Executive-Analyst Friendships

Disappointing Disconnection

There are challenges, of course – in an unbalanced friendship, Executives can find Analysts to be unrealistic and annoyingly focused on ideas rather than necessary action. The fact that Executives operate on the proven, while Analysts like to theorize, is a stumbling block even

in social or recreational matters. These two types might live in clashing mental time zones, with Executives focusing on what is, and Analysts on what might be. In unbalanced friendships, Executives may roll their eyes dismissively at Analysts' grand, esoteric plans, and may, in turn, be frustrated by Analysts' utter indifference to their more realistic interests.

To make this disconnection worse, Executives and Analysts both share a neglectful attitude toward maintaining friendships. Once they put in the initial effort to establish a solid rapport, both types may begin to take it for granted, thinking nothing of long silences or absences. This indicates a certain trust in each other, but functionally, such friends may simply drift apart through mutual carelessness and lack of effort. If they don't engage often enough, they miss out on the long-term benefits of the virtues they saw in each other in the first place.

Conflicts of Will

Another likely problem in unbalanced Executive-Analyst friendships is a clash of will. Analysts love to argue their interests and opinions, constantly trumpeting their views and mentally sparring with those who disagree. It's as if these conversations – or arguments – provide them with mental stimulation. Executives also hold firm views and are unlikely to back down, but because they don't share the joy of animated debate, they're quickly irritated by the ordeal of arguing with Analysts.

Sharing anything from political views to opinions on where to eat lunch can become frustrating for both types. Analysts may think Executives are dull-minded, and Executives, in turn, wonder if Analysts are all talk. Executives often just want a decision, not a debate, and may try to steamroll Analysts for the sake of a conclusion. Obviously, this can result in conflict. If these types don't find enough patience to talk things through, they eventually get fed up with each other's strong wills.

Rebalancing Executive-Analyst Friendships

Connecting to Each Other's Virtues

Executives and Analysts can build and maintain healthy connections by tapping into the logical benefits of being friends. Executives can foster

realism and grounded practicality – critical strengths that Analysts often lack. Given their reputation for rational thought, Analysts sometimes use oddly narrow reasoning to justify their moves, especially when fixated on an idea. Executives help them avoid getting lost in interesting possibilities, as well as encourage them to be mindful of looming probabilities. Executives might research and respectfully share some solid facts to counter Analysts' wilder ideas in an act of caring support, not criticism.

They can benefit from Analysts' clever, unconventional views, as their tried-and-true practices often prove limited. Times change, and they're always looking to optimize. Occasionally, changing their approach is an unavoidable part of this. Analysts love beating challenges through innovation, and Executives can call on their friends' creativity to help them find answers with their fresh perspective. Frequently requesting and offering input back and forth on everyday matters is a great way for these friends to stay involved each other's lives.

Considerate Honesty

Because of their aggressive intellect, it's difficult to match wits with Analysts, but Executives have the strength to firmly and fairly express themselves. They don't need to argue: if they calmly explain the reason for their preferences, they get results. It can be as simple as saying, "You always want to try new restaurants, but it bums me out when they don't have something I like. I'd go out more often if we could also visit my favorite places." There's no rational argument against mutual respect and consideration in friendships, but they require patient communication.

Consideration goes both ways, and Executives can work to respect Analysts' many ideas and preferences as well. Constantly resisting change or new ideas by saying, "I don't like it, so it's not worth my time," doesn't represent respectful investment in valued friends. They can support their Analyst friends' interests now and then, even if they're somewhat abstract and speculative. They can bring their more reserved rationality along for the ride, and expect to learn a few things.

Thoughtful Support

Functioning, balanced friendships with Analysts are certainly rewarding for both sides. Here are some benefits both types can keep in mind while trying to keep their friendships on the right track.

- Executives offer Analysts a sensible ear for their intellectual ranting that helps soothe their frustration with a dysfunctional world. Being dutiful, stable, and proactive is natural for these types, and Analysts need steadfast friends with minds sharp enough to understand them.
- In turn, Executives gain sincere, thoughtful support from their Analyst friends, whose vigorous minds are always at the ready. Analysts lead them to knowledge they might not discover through their more conventional perspective, but also offer nimble, reasoned reflection in times of trouble.

Finally, Analysts help Executives work through personal problems rationally without prying into their emotions too deeply, and this is a great comfort.

Executive-Diplomat Friendships

Executive-Diplomat friendships aren't always quick fits, but they do hold great potential, especially if shared interests are present. These personality types both want to make the world a better place, and deeply value cooperation, but take very different paths to this harmonious ideal. Executives vigorously implement systems to create functionality for all, and Diplomats create alignment by valuing individuals' emotions and needs. These friendships maintain balance when each accepts the way the other thinks and contributes – each brings a big dose of what the other lacks.

Balanced Executive-Diplomat Friendships

Compatible Values

One of the most rewarding parts of Executive-Diplomat friendships is their cooperation to bring their values into reality. Diplomats never tire of sharing ideas for improving the world, though they often fail to separate true idealism from realistic endeavors. Executives can sift through their bubbling idealism to find ideas that work, and help make them happen. When it comes to order, duty, and certainty, Executives relate well to the methods of Protagonists and Advocates, as the Judging trait offers an overlap in perspective.

Diplomats, especially Mediators and Campaigners, can be overly whimsical, but their creativity intrigues Executives. They make an effort to appreciate their friends' sometimes unusual paths, and find personal inspiration in their active imaginations. In turn, Diplomats in balanced friendships admire Executives' precise minds. Their instant grasp of reality is a refreshingly clear mode of thought to those whose own minds are whirling with many ideas. Patience is required for these very different types to form friendship, but it's a worthwhile effort with a big payoff for both types.

Discovering Knowledge

Executives thrive on knowledge, but despite their boldness, they aren't often adventurous by nature. This results in depth of experience, but not breadth – leaving them relatively unprepared when life brings the unfamiliar to their doorstep. However, Diplomats' empathetic friendship is the perfect vessel for Executives to try new things and broaden their capability. They're unlikely to push Executives into things they strongly disapprove of, as they're very attentive to their feelings. In this supportive atmosphere, Executives can take a few intellectual risks to grow and learn, knowing that the more they experience in life, the more successful their mastery of it.

The flip side is how wise and sensible Executives can be – they encourage and support their Diplomat friends by sharing realistic alternative ideas for achieving their grand dreams. They appreciate the way Executives forge smooth paths through life, tirelessly turning solid plans into stable reality. Their focused, energetic dedication is a lifeline

to Diplomats who feel lost in chaos. When these chums each put their best feet forward, they balance idealism and practicality to notably improve each other's lives.

Unbalanced Executive-Diplomat Friendships

Different Realities

Unfortunately, such friendships may experience friction with the realization that their differing approaches or belief systems are incompatible in certain situations. Executives look to the past for tried and true examples of what works best, while Diplomats happily embrace revolutionary change. In unbalanced situations, Diplomats may become frustrated at Executives' insistence on working toward stability instead of joining them in what they see as progress. Executives see following the rules as an ideal, and in turn, may become disturbed when they see Diplomat friends breaking the rules *for* an ideal. These two types often feel as though they're living in different worlds.

This really hits home when these types express opinions on what is or isn't fair. Executives see fairness in applying reasonable rules dispassionately and equally. Diplomats, on the other hand, like to create fairness through conditional approaches based on moral ideals. Executives may focus more on individual responsibility and drive to achieve equality, whereas Diplomats often focus on how people can establish equality by helping elevate each other.

Another difference is how Diplomats often chase unrealistic dreams. Executives find this behavior increasingly tiring when those dreams always seem to be on the horizon. These types respect realistic thinking, bold effort, and accomplishment, and are bothered by how willingly Diplomats – especially Campaigners and Mediators – embrace seemingly impossible dreams. Frustration can result if these friends can't reconcile their very different approaches to life.

Upsetting Each Other

The differences that can come to threaten these friendships aren't just about judgment or opinion: watching friends embrace things that seem imprudent, or even perilous, is frustrating for Executives. Whether it's

dubious romantic interests, implausible beliefs, or precarious financial habits, Diplomats' sometimes unbalanced, haphazard lifestyle worries characteristically practical Executives. They can feel frustrated when trying to avert Diplomat friends' questionable decisions, as pragmatic logic isn't always persuasive to those who live through emotion.

Unfortunately, Executives can also cause offense when they share sharply cautionary advice, no matter how true it is. They become critical when something seems flawed to them, and to Diplomats, this feels like someone stepping on their dreams. They're hurt by Executives' firm rejection of fantastical possibilities, seeing it as a lack of support. Such unbalanced conflicts threaten these friendships, as either type may become dismissive: Executives can become exasperated and unsympathetically "wash their hands" of the matter, and Diplomats may cease contact with those they see as fundamentally negative, a common misinterpretation of even the best-intentioned criticism or correction.

Rebalancing Executive-Diplomat Friendships

Explaining Perspectives

Resolving clashing views within Executive-Diplomat friendships requires a different approach from logical arguments. These friends don't need to agree with their lifestyles, but they can explain the adverse effects they feel from each other's behavior. For Executives, this may include functional concerns, and for Diplomats, it's more about feelings. Either way, honesty and respect are key. When Executives learn that their behavior is hurting their friends, reason dictates a change if those friends are truly valued and respected. Here are some ways Executives can approach conflicts with their Diplomat chums.

- When Executives take the time to gently explain why they're troubled, it appeals to Diplomats' sense of compassion, and they act accordingly. It can be as simple as saying, "That doesn't make sense to me. Can we talk things over together, so I can understand you better?" Logical facts aren't as important to Diplomats as their friends' welfare, and if asked respectfully to change their behavior a little, they're extremely receptive. These types needn't always see eye-to-eye to get along.

- The harder part for Executives is comprehending and meeting Diplomats' need for emotional support. An effective approach is to figure out Diplomats' implicit requests when they share their feelings, and give the desired responses. When these types express themselves, they're often just seeking validation and support. So, when Diplomats say, "I'm worried about making my rent," the response that best helps them might be, "Everything will be all right because I believe in you," rather than, "You should move to a more affordable place, so this doesn't keep happening."
- Less specific examples include listening and making friends feel valued by offering reassurance or encouraging input. There's also no harm in asking, "What can I do here to help you?" as Diplomats appreciate any sincere effort. This is also a supportive, subtle way for Executives to get Diplomat friends to consider the practicality of their ideas – how something might or might not be possible.
- Diplomats want attentive sympathy, and Executives can approximate this through deliberate acts of vigorous support. They can also gently tell Diplomats when they're truly at their limits of emotional understanding or participation in something foreign to them.

In turn, Diplomats can moderate their expectations, and respect Executives by not placing heavy demands on them to frequently engage in emotion or fanciful ideas. While Executives and Diplomats may grow very close, Diplomats can understand they may need to find deep emotional engagement among other friends.

Stepping In, and Stepping Back

Diplomats may be sensitive to criticism, but caring Executive friends recognize when it's time to offer their advice and help – and boldly step in, as is their nature. Executives can accept that Diplomats are dreamers, but there are moments when a more grounded perspective is vital, even if it isn't requested. It's not always easy to intervene, but they risk regret if avoiding emotional confrontations makes them withhold guidance from friends in trouble.

If their advice is ignored, Executives can respectfully retreat, making their ongoing support clear while holding true to their viewpoints. They may have little choice but to accept a continuous stream of

questionable ideas and choices from Diplomat friends. If this happens, Executives can take pragmatic solace in knowing that they tried to help, and decline to be drawn in. Avoiding participation in things they can't support helps them maintain healthy friendships with Diplomats, even if they require their stepping back now and then.

Executive-Sentinel Friendships

Other Sentinels are good fits for Executives, as they share an appreciation for dependability and practicality. These friendships support day-to-day activities and general quality of life more than change, ambition, or curiosity. Uncomplicated friendships with other Sentinels reassure and buoy Executives. Having others who are steadfast and sensible in their lives is no small consideration for these types.

Balanced Executive-Sentinel Friendships

Reassuring Steadiness

Executives also find other Sentinels' conventional social leanings appealing, whether such friends are Introverts or Extraverts. Their discussions revolve around grounded matters like work, current life events, and personal interests. Sentinels aren't big on esoteric topics, and consider those who constantly talk about broad, impersonal matters a bit baffling – they like to use the time to catch up with each other. Among Sentinel friends, Executives get a pleasant dose of real life rather than ideological grandstanding.

These friendships go beyond casual compatibility, however. When serious situations and major life events happen, Executives also appreciate how Sentinel friends stand by their side through thick and

thin. They offer the same in return, acting as strong, vocal supporters for those who earn their friendship. Executives and other Sentinels stand an excellent chance of becoming each other's best friends for a lifetime.

Stability in Action

Favoring stable foundations doesn't mean that these friends don't care about progress. However, where Intuitive or Prospecting types see a future teeming with endless possibilities, Executives like everything moving firmly in a controlled direction. Those with the Executive personality type may provide more energy than others ask for, but either way, having Sentinel friends with an organized way of living and equally sensible goals helps everyone keep moving forward.

When difficulties arise, Executives are often the first to step forward with a helping hand, and their Sentinel friends respect and sincerely appreciate their ready devotion. In turn, Sentinels' judicious touch perfect for Executives in times of trouble. Whether offering thoughtful solutions or simply some dutiful, hands-on help, these comrades are cores of support for each other. This creates the security they need to form deep and grateful bonds with each other.

Relatable Differences

Opposing personality traits may be easier for Executives to relate to when other Sentinels display them. Consuls' compassionate Extraversion inspires them toward warmth, as it demonstrates creating structure through personal connections. Defenders' quiet sensitivity is charming to Executives, and their pragmatic, patient acceptance creates a gentle sense of connection. The reserved, thoughtful nature of Logisticians impresses them, as they see how taking the time to contemplate things before acting assures absolute efficiency.

Different Sentinel friends offer Executives doorways to growth, expanding some of their limits while staying soberly grounded alongside them. Shared values focusing on stability, tradition, and dedication make friendships within this Role a good way for Executives to find supportive bonds.

Unbalanced Executive-Sentinel Friendships

Social Problems

While these types are compatible, Executives can fail Sentinels in emotionally charged situations such as breakups, arguments with other friends, or deaths in their families. Executives don't excel at interpersonal politics or hand-holding, and feel unhappily out of their depth when friends need understanding. Instead of showing warm, consoling reassurance, these types can point out problems in unbalanced ways and come up with dispassionate solutions, leaving other Sentinels feeling emotionally abandoned.

In turn, being in the middle of such situations can be baffling for Executives. When Sentinels experience sudden, serious problems, Executives may simply not have the emotional understanding to figure things out quickly enough to keep a handle on these situations. This can be extremely frustrating to a personality type that so deeply values control and personal capability. Executives do everything they can to avoid drama in their own lives, so they tend to resent it when friends bring such things to their doorstep.

Mutual Immobility

Executives and Sentinel friends build enjoyable, predictable routines together, but unwillingness to try new things can hold back their advancement on many fronts. Sentinels don't offer Executives much inspiration to make even beneficial changes to their lives, such as moving or going back to school. These friends may even shut out other worthy people who bring ideas that don't easily fit their social order. Instead of embracing the risks of ongoing development, these pals seek to reassure each other that things are OK.

Mutual reassurance provides a sense of comfort and solidity, but does little to motivate improvements. This isn't to say that these friends settle for failure, but they may settle for existing success. Even the most vigorous Executives rarely see the value in spontaneously changing what's proved to be a serviceable routine. Consequently, these friends may not push each other to excel beyond the security of conventional accomplishments. They do each other a disservice if they don't occasionally step out of such routines together to see what life can offer, and what they're truly capable of when they push their boundaries.

Rebalancing Executive-Sentinel Friendships

Rational Peacemakers

When Executives can't fully empathize with friends' emotional situations, they need not feel ineffective. Instead of artlessly trying to discuss feelings they don't know how to navigate, they can admit their limits while still offering firm support. Authenticity grants these types a strength that's reassuring to upset friends, so it's OK for them to say, "I don't fully understand how you feel, but I am always here for you." Sentinel friends are grateful for such caring that's sincere.

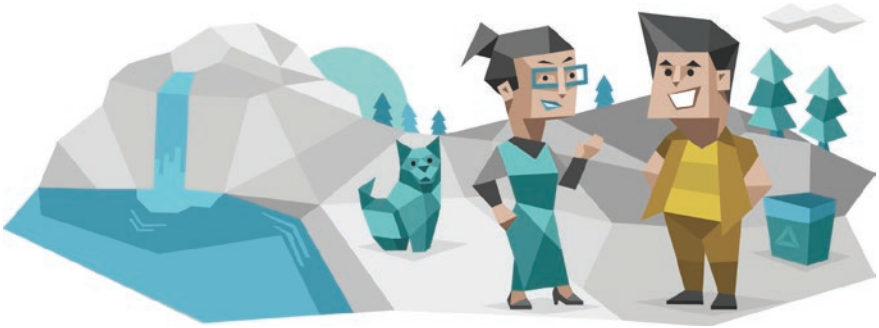
Once emotions have calmed a bit, Executives' detachment becomes an asset to friends in challenging situations. These types can take on roles of impartial observers, and try to help friends see practical moves that ease the situation. If friends are at odds, Executives are very confident and sensible mediators. Their preference for a clear understanding of the facts, and their relative comfort in rendering impartial judgment, helps them to stay fair for all parties concerned.

Sensible Change

Sentinels excel at being responsible, so Executives and Sentinels alike can keep an eye not just on each other's comfort and security, but on what truly benefits each other long-term. These friends wisely advise each other when they're in a rut, and offer ideas when change is needed to create success. When this requires embracing something new or unconventional, they can provide each other a judicious helping hand as well as supportive encouragement.

This applies to recreational pursuits as well as more serious matters, and these friends do well to try things out together. There's no need to leap off a cliff or take significant risks, but sampling new types of fun with trustworthy Sentinel friends leads to experiences that Executives wouldn't find on their own. These types aren't reluctant to take on challenges, and can likewise boldly explore new adventures. Engaging the unknown together, at least occasionally, is a smart way for these friends to explore their potential while sharing some fun.

Executive-Explorer Friendships



Friendships with Explorers are more likely to form through work, class, or mutual friends rather than direct social attraction, but they offer Executives some notable opportunities. Explorers live for the moment and its pleasures rather than long-term stability. At first, this seems reckless to Executives. However, their ability to lose themselves in enthusiasm is a great counterpoint to Executives' careful, methodical planning. These friendships provide a fresh outlook that helps Executives see a broader perspective on life.

Balanced Executive-Explorer Friendships

Zest for Life

Executives benefit from being led into fun and curiosity by their Explorer friends. Though it's not easy, Executives can practice relinquishing control and taking things as they come, especially in recreational matters where little is at stake. Developing adaptability without losing their cool is very useful for these types. They can't always predict what life throws at them. Friendship with Explorers is a wonderful way to practice mastering the unexpected, the unpredictable, and the uninhibited aspects of life.

Offering Guidance

Executives appreciate how Explorers' passion for discovery leads to knowledge, but also see how such carefree enthusiasm can result in unintended consequences. Supportive, tactical advice is where they shine in such friendships. When they earn their Explorer friends' trust, they become a respected voice of caution. While not expecting

Explorers to share their sense of moderation, they offer a respectful, steadying hand with just the right amount of reservation to prevent calamity.

Executives who come to trust Explorer friends can also accept their guiding hand to pull them out of their stoic sense of duty into some well-deserved gratification. They have a hard time realizing, admitting, and exploring their heartfelt inner desires. Explorers provide not only inspiration in this area, but practical help when Executives are ready to relax and have some fun.

Surprising Capability

At first, Executives assume that Explorers' more spontaneous style, so different from their rigid approach, isn't very effective. However, they're impressed when Explorer friends pursue things they care about to great success, and overcome challenges on the fly with adaptive tenacity. Explorers might change their minds frequently, but they throw themselves wholeheartedly into mastering interests that are important to them.

When those interests align with Executives' own, they find Explorer friends to be helpful, involved companions. Explorers add a little refreshing excitement to Executives' goals – and lives in general. For example, Adventurers' quiet curiosity introduces them to subtle experiences and knowledge they might miss on their own. They also very much appreciate the practical, hands-on side of Explorer friends. The intent way Virtuosos hone their skills is impressive even to such a capable type as Executives.

Motivation

Executives benefit from the undaunted, open-minded spirit of Explorers as well. The outward-focused vigor of Entrepreneur and Entertainer friends matches their energy, but with uninhibited enthusiasm. What Explorers lack in steadiness, they make up for with zeal, approaching experiences and challenges with a flexibility from which Executives can learn a lot.

In turn, Executives' organized effectiveness impresses Explorer friends, especially when aimed at a common goal. Explorers grab for what

they want, and as masters of logical planning and energetic execution, Executives can help them ensure success. These friends lend each other very different kinds of help to move successfully through life.

Unbalanced Executive-Explorer Friendships

Dangerous Games

There's a dark side to living in the moment, as a lack of consistency and forethought often brings about wild disorganization, social friction, and financial instability. Explorers' uninhibited lifestyle and impetuous decisions challenge Executives' boundaries of acceptance. Being exposed to too much chaos is deeply troubling – even offensive – to them. It's not in their nature to abandon friends, but they're quick to defend the stability of their own lives. They'll ultimately distance themselves if they feel threatened enough.

Explorers rarely understand or respect these doubts and reservations in unbalanced friendships, and they may either try to push Executives into things or lose patience and act without them. In unbalanced friendships, any idea of steadfast companionship can vanish into thin air when Explorers feel compelled to go in directions that Executives refuse to consider. This mutual disregard causes both types to question their friendships. Explorers resent the lack of support when they want to follow their hearts, and Executives dig in their heels, weary of ever-changing, exuberant disorder.

Disappointment and Frustration

A seemingly minor area where the often-fickle interests of Explorer friends can be very troubling for Executives is planning. Executives demand organization, and Explorers don't exactly operate that way. Friends being late for, altering, or canceling social engagements can be deeply frustrating to Executives. These picky types become overly critical when their value of reliability isn't reflected. In turn, Explorers are dismayed by their intolerance.

More seriously, Executives' difficulty with emotions and human connections is worsened in unbalanced friendships when Explorers' attention is easily pulled in new directions. It's hard for Executives

to communicate their feelings, even to highly reliable friends, as they dislike showing anything like vulnerability. Being let down by inconsistent people, unfortunately, reinforces this tendency to hide aspects of themselves.

Disappointment goes both ways in these unbalanced friendships, however. Executives offer Explorers little in the way of empathetic support, excitement, or the unknown, and their rigid methods of consideration often hinder adventure and discovery. Executives may not turn out to be the engaged, fun friends that Explorers seek, and Explorers don't put up with disappointment for very long.

Rebalancing Executive-Explorer Friendships

Respecting Limits and Needs

To achieve balance within their friendships, Executives and Explorers need to consciously recognize and accept their differences. These types frequently test each other, but this provides many opportunities for growth. Complaining isn't communication, and both must recognize when it's time to stop wasting energy on silent – or vocal – judgment. Instead, they can start talking about their needs gently, respectfully, and honestly with each other. Here are some ways these friends can grow their bonds.

- When Executives fairly communicate their true limits, Explorer friends can avoid pulling them too far out of their comfort zone. Conventional outings together – perhaps dining at favorite restaurants, shopping trips, or movies – are good ways for these friends to share some fun when Executives have had enough adventure. Explorers are all about indulgence and Executives appreciate familiarity, so they're wise to share some simple pleasures together.
- Likewise, Executives rarely back down from a challenge, and can stretch themselves when Explorers need company doing something exciting. An easy way for Explorers to encourage Executives to participate in such activities is to involve them in the planning, and then make sure they stick to the plan. Executives are a lot more willing to approach new things when the approach itself is well-organized.

- In any case, the importance of the friendships themselves form the common focus, with an understanding that sometimes compromises must be made for the sake of a worthy friend. Neither type needs to lead in a direction they find uncomfortable, but they can try to follow now and then. This kind of consideration isn't automatic or easy for either Executives or Explorers, but it's an area where both types greatly benefit from conscious improvement.

Detached Understanding

There may also be times when these friends are wise to just do their own thing. It may not be obvious, but pulling back and letting others make their own decisions is a sign of tremendous respect from Executives, and true friends deserve that respect. When Explorers engage in something too extreme for Executives to support, they can practice respectful, rational detachment. There's no shame in letting their friends be wild and free without them for a while. They can hear the stories and laugh together afterward.

Explorers can appreciate this respect, even if it doesn't always come with participation or complete approval. In return, they can respect Executives' limits, and understand that not everyone has as much excited curiosity in the face of the unknown. When Executives need order, Explorers can just wait until they're ready and make another friendly offer later – no pressure. For these friends, respectfully giving each other room to be themselves is necessary, and they can come back together later for something they both enjoy.

Conclusion

Mutual support and shared fun are among the greatest benefits of friendship. These might not seem like top priorities to a type as driven and grounded as Executives, but for all their logic, they're still social creatures. Connecting to other people is an integral part of their journey toward status, success, and happiness. These types know the value of networking, and the efficient strength found in cooperation.

Once they come to truly know other people, their assumptions and beliefs are in for some challenges, but Executives are up for that challenge. Applying their judicious value of fairness is an excellent

way for these types to be open to beneficial friendships with people who think and act differently. They're strong enough not just to hold convictions, but to explore other ideas and lifestyles through worthy, capable friends.

Progress aside, Executives who take the time to focus some energy on friendships instead of just life goals also receive a kind of inner fulfillment that's a prize unto itself. Status and success are genuinely valuable things, but having true friends who respect and appreciate the individuals behind all that hard work is priceless. Executives who invest in their friendships ensure that they always have someone not only to congratulate their triumphs, but also to share laughter, trust, and joy with them.

Parenthood

Responsible and Respectable

The Executives' mantra of "hard work, tradition, respect" is best exemplified in their relationships with their children. In many ways, they're the classic 1950s era parental figures – strict guardians of family traditions who have no trouble enforcing the rules and standards they've established while also providing solid, pragmatic wisdom. Often seen as model citizens, these types expect their children to continue the example they've set by being polite and respectful.

Executives have a very responsibility-oriented view of life. They share a firm belief in the idea that one does what one can to contribute to the family and the community. This view is, of course, extended to their children. As soon as they're able, their kids are expected to contribute in their way, by cleaning their plates, keeping their rooms tidy, and going to bed on time – by maintaining the order of things.

It's not that they have wild, high-flying hopes of perfection for their children. Executives are down-to-earth people, and merely want to see their kids develop into respected, responsible adults. However, they also want them to be decisive and capable, which can only happen with the chance to make their own decisions – and to face the consequences of those choices, good or bad, with their parents' love and support.

While yielding control may be difficult, Executives can exercise patience and restraint by allowing their children to fall off their bikes, fail tests they didn't study for, or have their hearts broken by unrequited young

love. These youthful afflictions provide opportunities for parents to teach caution, resilience, and thoughtful problem-solving skills that can benefit their children for the rest of their lives.

Loyal and Honest

The moment they become parents, these types become unequivocally devoted to raising their kids to the best of their abilities. Their loyalty is unwavering, and they're fully committed to providing everything necessary for their children to be successful in life, though this is very different from giving their children everything that they want. Using their natural ability to organize and delegate tasks, Executives can create a stable and secure environment where their kids can truly thrive.

Because their parents are never the type to mince words, Executives' children always know exactly what's expected of them. These expectations are likely to be thoroughly outlined and reinforced consistently – and their parents provide feedback on how well they're meeting these expectations on a regular basis. Though they may not always communicate it sensitively, this feedback is still candid and sincere.

Perhaps the most significant and enduring aspect of Executives' loyal, honest nature is the fact they're modeling these virtues to their children. They expect their kids to value these traits as well, and emphasize this at every opportunity. Consistently observing and experiencing the benefits of the loyalty and honesty their parents exude instills their importance. Children of Executive parents are likely to respect and reciprocate these often-neglected virtues.

Overly Controlling

With their desire to always do "what's best" for their children, Executives can quickly spiral into unbalanced, excessively controlling behavior. They're the personality type most likely to believe they should guide their kids' education, and the type least inclined to think they need to give children the freedom to develop. This system of beliefs can create a repressive environment, which prevents children from engaging with their naturally curious instincts. Without the opportunity to freely

explore their surroundings, pursue their interests, and make mistakes, youngsters can never develop the ability to take the initiative or bounce back from failures.

Unbalanced controlling behavior tends to present itself in negative ways, especially during stressful situations. Executives who believe their children are being particularly difficult may dole out punishments that are harsher than necessary. Even small transgressions can seem like personal affronts to their authority, causing offended parents to become disconcerted. Discipline then becomes their primary tool for keeping their children in line and making sure they follow the rules.

When parental discipline is focused entirely on punishment, children lose out on the opportunity to truly learn from their mistakes. Constant criticism of their behavior, rather than encouragement to improve, often manifests in kids as a sense of defeat. They may think, "Why bother, I'm not going to ever meet their expectations." When they consistently feel this level of frustration, they may either become withdrawn or begin acting out – feeling that what they do doesn't matter because they can't please their parents either way. Whether children should response this way or not isn't relevant in this situation. The fact is, they can, and it's up to Executive parents to guide their development sensibly and realistically under the circumstances. Ignoring the facts doesn't help anyone.

Lacking Warmth and Sensitivity

When children need the warmth and sensitivity of emotional support, all the loyalty, devotion, and structure that Executive parents model are of little use. While these types can be sensitive in their way toward those they care about, it's hard for younger children and adolescents to recognize this tough love for the love that it is. These parents may need to rely on more sensitive or empathic partners to fill this role and create balance between clear, rational purpose and a harder-to-define sense of emotional well-being.

Other situations that may inhibit them from parenting as effectively as they would like are those where empathy is needed. Children make mistakes, act irrationally, and routinely test boundaries, making interacting with them incredibly frustrating at times. Executives' lack

of sensitivity can cause them to interact with their kids in less-than-understanding ways, creating a cycle of frustration and anger for both parents and children. Kids with the Feeling trait may especially be crushed by what they perceive to be a rejection of their emotions – or even themselves – and can display this in fearfulness, becoming withdrawn, and acting out.

Creating Learning Opportunities

It's easy to become caught up in controlling behaviors. Children certainly need structure and benefit significantly from organized households. However, excessive control of their environment, combined with unrealistic expectations, can result in youngsters who are unable to regulate their behavior. Rather than focusing purely on controlling their children, Executives can concentrate on providing them with opportunities to learn how to control themselves.

If there's anything that these parents hope to accomplish, it's to raise children who are hardworking, capable, and responsible, just like they are. The best way to teach these lessons is by modeling, which Executives excel at, and allowing their children to learn through trial and error. Mistakes can be made into opportunities to create teachable moments rather than inflicting punishment.

Toddlers may undoubtedly spill their milk the first time they try to make cereal by themselves. Parents who show them how to clean up their spill, and carefully model how to pour milk without spilling, experience less frustration than those who immediately put their little ones in time-out. Not only are they teaching them a valuable skill, but they're also preventing the inevitable meltdown that occurs when toddlers feel they're unjustly punished. This technique takes more time up front, but saves a great deal of time in the future as their children become more competent and confident in their abilities.

Developing Effective Emotional Expression

In addition to creating learning opportunities out of mistakes, Executives who desire meaningful relationships with their children must work toward building strong emotional bonds. Improving their emotional expression, or how they communicate their feelings with

others, benefits their relationships with their kids as well as anyone else with whom they're in regular contact. This aspect of personal growth can be daunting, and these types may fight the process by continually arguing against its merits. Parenthood, however, is a very motivating experience and may provide just the right level of pressure to convince Executives that it's worthwhile.

To improve their emotional expression, they may need to look at whether their communication with their children is overly critical or insensitive. As a dominant personality type, they may inadvertently steamroll their children when trying to talk through their expectations. Kids who either withdraw or act out aggressively when frustrated may feel as though their parents are demanding too of much of them without taking the time to listen to their own needs and desires. Honest, patient listening skills and measured, considerate responses can garner more respect and more positive reactions from children of every age.

Parenting for Each Stage of Development

Each stage of children's growth presents both unique challenges and exciting milestones. Learning how to navigate these stages can seem daunting, but the opportunity to build healthy attachments and create meaningful memories makes it worth the struggle.

Renowned psychologist Erik Erikson proposed a theory of psychosocial development that identified eight stages, five of which take place between birth and 18 years of age. It's important to remember that these stages aren't set in stone, and the ages listed for each stage are approximate. Children develop at their own pace and meet each milestone in their own time. The following paragraphs briefly discuss what to expect at each stage of development, as well as how the strengths and weaknesses of the Executive personality type can affect their parenting at each stage.

Building Bonds (Birth–1½ Years)

According to Erikson, the stages of infancy and early childhood last from birth until approximately three years of age. Children in these stages are very dependent on their parents to meet their needs. This is also when the bonds of attachment are created by meeting children's needs, developing trusting relationships, and promoting autonomy.

The priority for infants in their journey to attachment is having their basic needs met. From being fed to receiving affection, they learn to either trust that their Executive parents can provide for them, or they suffer from a sense of mistrust in all their subsequent relationships. If these types are inconsistent in providing for their children, or are especially violent or neglectful – an extreme situation, to be sure – their children can have difficulty creating positive, trusting attachment.

Attentive, affectionate parents, especially those who engage in consistent physical contact such as snuggling or transporting their children in baby carriers on their bodies, can develop trusting, hopeful relationships with their infants and are likely to have little difficulty building comfortable attachments.

Balanced Infant Parenting

Building Reliable Bonds

Executives excel at providing structure for their children and are certainly able to meet their infants' needs in this regard. Reliability is vital in building relationships with infants, and these parents are likely to be very attentive to their babies by dependably feeding, changing, and comforting them when necessary. Most Executives enjoy the infant stage, where their children rely on them entirely for meeting their needs, and won't hesitate to provide for them consistently in patient and, ideally, caring ways.

As parents, these types have an extreme sense of duty to meet their children's needs, which can be motivating during the extraordinarily draining infant stage. Where some parents may struggle with maintaining energy during this phase, leading to mood swings or other inconsistent behaviors, Executives not only survive this stage but even enjoy it. They can create a foundation for building trust and instilling hope in their infants.

Endless Energy

Sleepless nights are inevitable, and exhaustion is almost certainly guaranteed during this stage. Executive parents have an advantage in this regard, as they're high energy and are the least likely personality type to tire easily. This power can carry them through especially exhausting days.

In addition to having the momentum needed to power through their sleep deprivation, their excess energy, if utilized effectively, can help to insulate them from some of the issues caused by exhaustion, such as feeling anxious, sad, or overwhelmed. While all new parents have these feelings to some extent (and if they're severe or continue for several days, consult a medical professional), Executives may thrive on and revel in the opportunity to make order out of the chaos.

Unbalanced Infant Parenting

Inadequate Affection

Although they're extraordinarily attentive and reliable, parents with the Executive personality type may need to focus on regularly providing intentional affection. During the infant stage, babies who don't receive adequate physical contact with caregivers can struggle with bonding and trust. In severe cases, infants who go without loving physical contact can experience a failure to thrive, resulting in emotional, intellectual, and behavioral issues that could continue to plague them in future relationships.

Most Executive parents are unlikely to completely deprive their children of physical contact, but they may see interactions with their babies as necessary exchanges rather than opportunities to promote bonding. They may be tempted to let their children "cry it out" when it's time for them to sleep, even though they may respond more positively to rocking or a soothing lullaby. Adapting to their infants' unique needs during this time can be especially frustrating for this personality type who prefers to do things their way.

Struggling with Expectations

In addition to struggling with expressing affection, Executives may have unrealistic expectations of their children during this stage. While they certainly understand their infants' capabilities at this point, they may expect them to achieve certain milestones more quickly than is necessary, or fret that their children aren't hitting milestones "on time." Specifically, they may be more concerned about getting their children to sit up, roll over, feed themselves, or walk before they're truly ready, rather than appreciating their current abilities and engaging with them at their level.

It's certainly exciting to see babies roll over for the first time or sit up on their own. However, trying to push children to achieve these milestones too soon only causes frustration for everyone involved. Just because their infants aren't saying their first words at the same time as their friend's children doesn't mean they aren't as intelligent. Development, especially at this stage, isn't a measure of parental ability, and both Executive parents and their infants are likely to be much happier and more relaxed if they're allowed to grow and develop at their own pace.

Rebalancing Infant Parenting

Determining Developmental Needs

At this stage, it's important to understand that developmental milestones are approximate and aren't set in stone. Additionally, little ones who attain certain milestones earlier aren't necessarily "advanced," and those who achieve them later aren't always "delayed." Labeling children as advanced or delayed, especially this early, can be detrimental to their lifelong development and self-esteem.

Pediatricians and family physicians are parents' best resource for determining whether they should be concerned about their children's development. These professionals can provide resources that cover what to expect at different stages regarding physical, intellectual, psychological, and behavioral development. Regular appointments with physicians ensure that any issues are addressed as soon as possible, and can help to put Executive parents' mind at ease.

Interacting with Affection

Executives are extraordinarily motivated by a sense of duty to their families and can excel at parenting through the infancy stage if they take steps to overcome potential weaknesses. They're generally hesitant to express their emotions, but innocent children, especially those who reciprocate their feelings through smiles, giggles, and other positive reactions, can bring out Executive parents' sensitive, silly, loving sides.

Reciprocating their laughter, facial expression, and even hand motions encourages bonding and builds the neural pathways necessary for children to learn. Cuddling, keeping their infants in wearable children-carriers, talking in a soothing voice, singing, and encouraging eye contact are additional physical ways that Executives can foster meaningful, deep attachment with their babies.

Testing Boundaries (1½–3 Years)

Once they're mobile, young children become very interested in exploring their environment with their senses. Crawling, walking, grabbing items, putting things in their mouths, and verbal communication are just a few of the ways that toddlers learn about the world around them.

During this stage, parents must provide a safe harbor for their children while still allowing them to experience and explore their surroundings. Children permitted to test boundaries yet are still receiving parental support and encouragement can develop a sense of autonomy. Those who are overly restricted, criticized, or made to feel guilty for their desire to test boundaries can ultimately experience a sense of shame and may suffer from feelings of incompetence or low self-worth. These feelings can last throughout their lives, and may eventually jeopardize their ability to achieve goals and develop positive character traits such as reliability or confidence.

Balanced Toddler Parenting

Patient and Supportive

Executives' patience and stamina are especially useful during the difficult toddler years. While this stage can certainly be challenging, these

parents enjoy promoting their children's curiosity and independence while still maintaining a safe environment. They take pleasure in helping their children learn how to pick out their clothes and dress themselves, and how to use and manipulate toys and tools (such as forks and spoons). Teaching their children to become self-reliant and competent are among these parents' greatest joys.

Incredibly supportive, Executives make an ideal "home base" for their toddlers during at this point as well. Their consistency and reliability can ensure that their little ones never feel abandoned, ignored, or unloved. Even though children at this age are incredibly independent, they still crave (and need) trustworthy caregivers who can meet all their needs, and Executives won't disappoint.

Providing Safe Boundaries

Known for running a tight ship, Executives excel at setting up reasonable boundaries that allow toddlers to feel as though they're unrestricted, but still feel controlled by them as parents. The perception they're allowed to play or explore freely is especially crucial for toddlers working to build a sense of autonomy. Something as simple as setting up spaces where their toddlers can color, glue, and paint without worrying about the mess, or allowing them to pick out their own books at the library, can feel incredibly liberating.

Providing a safe, structured environment gives Executives the sense of control they need to remain confident in their abilities. When constructed correctly, this structure can expand and contract based on their children's needs. As their children grow and mature, Executive parents can gradually increase the boundaries they've set to provide for more opportunities and independence. On the other hand, parents can choose to tighten them for children who struggle with limits that provide a level of ambiguity they aren't prepared to deal with. The toddler years may be the first time Executive parents need to fully utilize their natural ability to determine and successfully create the boundaries their children need.

Unbalanced Toddler Parenting

Authority Issues

On the flip side, this stage can be especially challenging for Executive parents, as they can have difficulty accepting their children's desire to push boundaries. From insisting on dressing themselves (and choosing their uncoordinated clothing) to refusing to eat any form of fresh produce (or any healthy food for that matter), toddlers often seem as though they're challenging their parents' authority at every turn. There's a delicate balance to be achieved between providing a safe space to explore and not overly controlling their children's environment. Toddlers who wish to do things independently can become increasingly frustrated by parents who continually deny them these opportunities.

Parents with the Executive personality type can be offended by kids who appear to challenge their authority or don't display expected behavior, especially in public. Hierarchies are to be respected, especially between parents and children, and when their authority is questioned or ignored, these parents are likely to become frustrated. It doesn't help that their toddlers are likely to acquire a new favorite word they can use forcefully and frequently, "No." Executives don't approve of being challenged and may find this stage of their children's development to be one of the most difficult to reconcile.

Rebalancing Toddler Parenting

Promoting Responsible Independence

Children at this stage seek both security and increasing autonomy, and Executives need to tow the fine line between patiently supporting this desire to explore and upholding essential rules to ensure their safety. Here are some tips these parents can try.

- Finding ways to involve them in household chores, or giving them options such as, "Would you like to wear your red shirt or blue shirt today?" can enhance not only their skills but their sense of autonomy and achievement as well, making them more confident and secure in their abilities.

- It's easy to become frustrated when toddlers appear to be continually questioning authority, but it's important to understand the necessity of testing boundaries at this stage. Children need to learn how to act independently and become self-reliant, and they do this by testing their parents' authority.
- It helps to look at discipline, especially during this stage, as a learning opportunity for kids rather than as a form of punishment.
- For example, toddlers trying to get their parents' attention may attempt to do so through hitting or yelling. Rather than shouting back or putting them in time-out, Executive parents can first practice engaging with the children through eye contact, crouching to meet them at eye level, hand holding, or hugging.

After toddlers feel connected, their parents can use these opportunities to help their children develop better ways of looking for attention. This can take practice and consistency, and Executives excel at both.

Thirst for Knowledge (3–5 Years)

The preschool years, from approximately three to five years of age, are a prime time for brain development, and little ones accumulate knowledge at an extraordinary rate through constant activity and a seemingly infinite range of questions. Learning at this stage takes place through play, especially the unstructured kind, and lots of social interaction with family and peers. Creativity is also exercised extensively through imaginary play, make-believe games, and stories.

To master this stage, children must be given the opportunity to not only make some of their own decisions, but also be allowed to initiate activities, ask questions (and receive answers), and lead others in exploration play. Youngsters who aren't given these opportunities – or are made to feel as though their constant questions or childish make-believe games are annoying – can experience feelings of guilt, frustration, and a lack of competence. Consequently, they may suffer from poor self-control or a lack of initiative.

Balanced Preschool Parenting

Natural Teachers

Executives are both patient and self-confident, which are valuable traits when parenting curious, active young children. They happily answer their preschool children's seemingly ceaseless stream of questions and take great pleasure in modeling practical skills, such as sweeping or washing dishes. Imparting their knowledge in practical, useful ways is one of Executive parents' greatest strengths.

Practical skills and academics aren't the only topics these parents value – instilling a sense of character into their children from a young age is just as important to Executives as any set of skills. They teach their children to respect authority, from teachers to elderly neighbors. They insist upon honesty, and are the type of parents who order their preschoolers to not only apologize to a neighbor whose flowers they dug up but also help them to replant those flowers. These parents feel it's their moral obligation to instill these important principles through modeling and consistent reinforcement.

Promoting Confidence

Additionally, these types are incredibly confident in their abilities, and rightly so, as they're especially dedicated, motivated, and competent. These individuals can achieve whatever they set out to do. This is an incredibly helpful mindset to model and pass on to children, especially during the preschool and school years – the stage for increasing both confidence and competence.

As natural leaders themselves, Executives have well-developed decision-making skills and an incredible amount of initiative – qualities that are vital for preschool-aged children to learn. As an often-assertive personality type, Executives parents can actively encourage their children to step up and develop leadership skills. At this stage, they can expect their kids to introduce themselves to other children at the playground, and use their problem-solving skills to deal with any difficult-to-play-with children they encounter. They're unlikely to pander to their preschoolers' desire for them to solve any issues they may face. Instead, Executives can work with them to figure out age-appropriate solutions to their problems.

Unbalanced Preschool Parenting

Lacking Adaptability

Although they love promoting learning, these types may have difficulty following their children's lead during the preschool years. Parents may struggle with the spontaneous needs kids often present at especially inopportune times. As very schedule-driven, timely individuals, they can be annoyed by preschoolers who are more interested in their coloring pages than getting their shoes on when it's time to leave. Temper tantrums and bathroom emergencies can derail the best-laid plans, and Executives who focus on maintaining tight schedules can frustrate both themselves and their children.

This lack of adaptability can also manifest as an inability to interact with their children in silly, playful ways. Parenting is serious business for Executives, who may struggle with their children's desire to engage in make-believe play or sing goofy songs, especially if they ask their parents to join in. Spontaneous play isn't Executives' strong suit or something they necessarily wish to cultivate in their children, and they may find it downright annoying.

Occasionally Overbearing

Another area Executive parents can have difficulty with is genuinely embracing unstructured play. These types may fall prey to the idea that free play isn't as valuable as "educational" play or structured activities, and may focus their energy on providing learning experiences rather than allowing their children to take the lead. If they take their love of routine and structure too far, Executives may leave too little room for their children to make the discoveries – and even important mistakes – they need to develop competence and initiative.

This tendency to be overbearing can be especially damaging to children who are Introverted or Feeling types who struggle with social interaction or feel overwhelmed by displays of dominance. Extraverted Executive types may mistake Introverted children's lack of desire to interact with peers at the park as a serious lack of social skills instead of an utterly legitimate personality trait. Preschoolers who cry easily when their parents raise their voices may be seen as "cry-babies" in need of "toughening up." These types may view sensitivity as a weakness

to be corrected, rather than a trait that requires a different style of communication from their parents.

Rebalancing Preschool Parenting

Increasing Flexibility

Learning to gauge their children's developmental readiness can be difficult for Executives who have become too focused on timely achievement. Rather than constantly worrying about their children's development, these parents can focus on allowing them to develop them organically. Children don't need an excessive number of play dates, "educational" toys and games, or structured learning periods throughout the day. Playing with simple toys allows them to engage their imagination, the fundamental building block for developing their ability to gain knowledge as they grow.

Being flexible doesn't have to mean all play and no work. One way these parents can promote both learning and autonomy without being overly controlling is to allow their children to define their "lesson" for the day.

- If their kids want to go to the zoo, make a point to ask them questions about the animals they see.
- Seek out answers to any questions they may have about the creatures they're observing.
- If they're playing outside, help them to identify bugs, birds, trees, and flowers in a playful way. Just giving a name to the bird they're observing – "That black and white bird is a magpie!" – is learning.

Children allowed to seek out learning experiences on their own at this stage are much more likely to do so throughout their lives.

Embracing Play Time

To add even more benefit for both themselves and their children, Executives can take time to engage in play. A game of hide-and-seek, sitting on the floor putting together a puzzle, or playing with toys are all great ways to both model the benefits of play and to enhance the parent-child bond. Additionally, unstructured play time is vitally

important for children at this stage to gain competence, confidence, and initiative.

Executives must learn to let their kids have plenty of free play time, ideally with lots of time outdoors in nature, without a specific agenda. Even boredom is valuable, as this is when children feel the need to try new things and learn new skills. Preschoolers with this type of freedom can gain confidence in their abilities and be more inclined to intentionally seek out educational opportunities later in life.

Creating Competence (5–12 Years)

The early school years are an important period of skill development for young children. Not only are they still continually absorbing new information, but they're also working on becoming proficient in increasingly complex areas, from relationships to mathematics to athletics. Children who are both challenged and supported in these areas can flourish in both their abilities as well as their self-confidence. If they don't receive consistent support at this stage, they can begin to feel inferior to their peers and are less likely to develop or work toward achieving long-term goals. On the other hand, if they aren't sufficiently challenged, they may begin to feel overly confident in themselves and their abilities, and can lack modesty and compassion toward others.

Balanced School-Age Parenting

Supportive and Pragmatic

As they strive to be capable students themselves, Executives can promote obedience, attentiveness, and respect for authority in their children as well. The school years, whether spent in "traditional" educational environments or not, focus on the development of academic skills and obtaining proficiency. Executive parents tend to provide the necessary structure to help their children succeed, whether it's helping with homework, finding a tutor, or even just providing consistent support for frustrated kids.

While very supportive and encouraging of their children, Executives balance out these traits with their focus on duty and pragmatism. They're

no strangers to hard work themselves, and can encourage children of all levels and abilities to achieve their personal best. These parents are proud of their children's accomplishments. However, they loathe arrogance, and won't hesitate to call out kids engaging in conceited or pretentious behavior. These pragmatic types expect achievement and advise their children to focus on the task at hand instead of seeking out acknowledgment for every little accomplishment.

Excellent Mentors

The school years are a time of intense learning, and Executives are natural teachers who have no trouble modeling the skills needed for academic success as well as real-world skills. Ever the pragmatists, Executive parents won't shy away from teaching their children the value of hard work and the importance of traits such as dependability and persistence.

Practical skills are just as necessary as academics, and these parents are likely to take every opportunity to pass on these skills. They can teach even young children age-appropriate ways to help with cooking, cleaning, and home maintenance. In fact, these teaching moments may be one of the primary ways that Executive parents spend time bonding with their children. Working on the car together, showing them how to make cookies, and even teaching them how to do laundry are all fantastic opportunities to model skills and build their relationships with their children. Relationships are built on quality time spent together, and helping their youngsters learn how to succeed in life is unequivocally high-quality time.

Unbalanced School-Age Parenting

Overly Concerned with Achievement

Executives can become overly concerned about making sure that their children are genuinely "good kids," meaning they're successful in school, socially connected, engaged in hobbies, and well-behaved. This mindset can prove especially detrimental to children at this stage by indicating that academic achievement and good behavior are more important than holistic growth or their personal interests. From

Scouting programs to swimming lessons, parents may place a great deal of emphasis on extracurricular activities they believe can help their children be "successful" without realizing they're overburdening them.

Executive parents who elevate their expectations to this extent may experience emotional outbursts from their children when they become fed up by an excessive focus on how they appear to others rather than how they feel. Conversely, less confident kids may struggle to voice their frustration and, instead of rebelling, can become overly dependent on their parents' approval. This may result in difficulty setting their own goals and can lead to a struggle to achieve a healthy level of independence later in life.

Critical Without Appreciation

Another area where Executive parents struggle is their emphasis on success over learning "how to learn." True learning is often a product of failure, which is a hard concept for many parents to grasp. Kids who struggle in math class that, through hard work and time with a tutor, manage to raise their grades from an 'F' to a 'C,' are learning. Parents who overly focus on success in the form of all 'A's on their report card, may not view their children's 'C's as proof of learning, regardless of the great strides they've made.

All children are different, and their unique talents, skills, and abilities should be taken into consideration before others criticize their shortcomings. Executive parents can be quick to point out faults in their children's performance or behavior. They believe that addressing these issues is more important than appreciating or acknowledging their children's strengths and achievements. They may think, "They're already getting good grades in English, so why should I worry about praising them for getting an 'A' on their paper? I expect that." This can have a devastating effect on children who feel their parents only see their faults. They may become withdrawn or start acting out – believing nothing they can do is good enough to please their overly critical parents, anyway.

Rebalancing School-Age Parenting

Constructing Values Together

As much as Executive parents may want their children to succeed in specific areas, it's more important they focus on promoting their overall well-being. They're very devoted to their principles, especially responsibility and duty, as well as their children. Using their devotion, these types can create a definition of success that embraces a more holistic idea of what success truly means. Determining and promoting their personal principles can help them guide their kids toward developing their principles and pursuing their definitions of a successful life. Here are some steps Executive parents can take to do this.

- Executives can start this process by looking at institutions that have played an important part in their lives, such as their faith, their family, or even their alma mater.
- Once they've determined the sources of some of their principles, they can extrapolate the values they learned or developed because of their experiences with those institutions. Their faith may have provided them with a policy of honesty, their family may have instilled a deep sense of responsibility, and an alma matter may have helped to develop their value of hard work.
- These parents may identify dozens of principles that are important to them, but for this process it's best to focus on three to five principles they'd like to emphasize for themselves and their children.
- Once selected, Executive parents should define how they can personally practice and model these values. A sense of responsibility can be both practiced and modeled by taking their children with them to volunteer at a soup kitchen.
- They can practice hard work in their career, but an effective way to model it to children who don't see what they do at the office is to work on a project with their kids. Projects could range from restoring an old car their children may someday drive to learning a language together in preparation for a family trip to a foreign country.

Discovering and acting on such principles can be a daunting process. There are so many outside factors – such as teachers, peers, and even media sources – telling people what they should prioritize. It may be

difficult, but Executives who take the time to engage in this process with their children won't only promote their positive values, they'll likely grow closer to their children as well. Once they've gone through this process, parents can rest assured they've done what they can to raise competent, confident children with a firm sense of what they value.

Find Thyself (12–18 Years)

During this stage of development, adolescents are transitioning from childhood to adulthood and developing their distinct sense of identity. This centers around their understanding of what their roles are in their relationships with themselves, others, and society in general. To determine their roles, teens can begin the all-important process of identifying their personal values and beliefs. Future education and career goals can be made, and relationships can be developed based on how they align with these values and beliefs, making this a pivotal stage for the rest of their lives.

Balanced Adolescent Parenting

Promoting Positive Principles

During this stage of identity development, adolescents need the support and understanding of their parents more than ever. Executive parents can encourage their teenagers' growth by promoting such positive principles as responsibility, integrity, and reliability while providing a stable and loving environment. Although they may struggle with gradually decreasing the amount of control they exert over their children, Executives are still interested in assisting them in the process of personal development to the best of their ability.

Regardless of the struggles they may face during this tumultuous time, these types can remain patient and steadfast in their devotion to their children. Their reliability, both in their attention and promotion of their kids' positive principles, can provide a solid framework that allows identity-seeking teens to venture further into self-discovery while still feeling a sense of stability and love.

Honest and Dependable

As Holden Caulfield, the protagonist in J.D. Salinger's classic novel, *The Catcher in the Rye*, points out, there's very little that adolescents hate more during this idealistic stage than phonies. Executives also loathe dishonesty, and are at their best when they can provide frank, forthright information. Their no-nonsense approach, applied not as criticism but as a way of responding to questions and giving advice, makes teens feel like they're being treated more as adults, and with more respect.

If these parents can maintain this same frank, yet patient pragmatism when their kids come to them with something dire – getting pregnant, getting suspended or expelled, or even a rough breakup – they can establish themselves as a dependable source of stability and wisdom when their children need it most. As chaotic and terrifying as some of these situations may seem, Executive parents can tap into their confidence and dependability and focus on aspects of these situations on which they can follow through.

Unbalanced Adolescent Parenting

Overly Traditional

Parents with the Executive personality type may have difficulty accepting certain aspects of their children's newfound identities during this stage. Their strong principles often coincide with a preference for "traditional" roles, and teenagers who push the boundaries of these roles too dramatically could both shock and frustrate Executives. Making sure their children's values align with their personal and family principles is of utmost importance to them.

They base their expectations of childhood on their past experiences, and societal changes that take place with each new generation can be both confusing and frustrating. Their adolescent children may appear almost unrecognizable as they attempt to determine if the principles and traditions they were raised with truly represent who they hope to become. With their principles challenged, Executives may believe that their children have abandoned their values, making them feel as though they have failed as parents.

Intolerant and Unforgiving

Executive parents can be both intolerant and unforgiving of the mistakes their teens are bound to make. While all parents struggle with the challenges presented during the adolescent years, Executives can effectively shut down their relationships with their children with their lack of tolerance. Experimentation is prevalent throughout this stage, with adolescents doing anything from trying alcohol to engaging in sexual activities. While they must establish firm rules, these parents must also be open to forgiving their teenagers' indiscretions and focus on helping them learn from mistakes.

Criticism and constant reminders of any missteps they may have made can certainly breed resentment in their children. Rather than forgiving their transgressions and helping their kids deal with the resulting consequences of their actions, Executives may focus on holding those mistakes over their children's heads as reminders of their failure. Often, they believe this is the best way to be sure that their teens won't repeat these mistakes. Unfortunately, unconstructive criticism comes across as mean and unfair at a time when children most need understanding and context to help them learn from their struggles.

Rebalancing Adolescent Parenting

Modeling Personal Growth and Understanding

Understanding is vital during this stage, as their children's needs can change, and their independence can grow with each year. Constant rebalancing of responsibility and expectations are required as adolescent children strive to become more capable, responsible, and mature. It can be difficult for Executives to decrease the amount of control they exert over their kids – not necessarily because they view them as incapable, but because they genuinely believe they know best. It's helpful for parents at this stage to encourage their children to develop their own personal values – here are some ideas Executives can try.

- While they can draw from family values to do so, kids should be allowed to privately focus on embracing values that are meaningful to their individual journeys.

- Most importantly, Executives can take such opportunities to engage in some self-reflection as well, perhaps even taking time to rediscover old hobbies, find a club or class to join, or become more involved in a community group or project.
- Modeling is the best way to pass principles and values to children, and parents can benefit from focusing on their personal growth, showing what productive, happy, and responsible adults do with their time.

Engaging in Active Listening

Finally, Executive parents should practice listening to their children's needs, thoughts, and concerns in open, non-judgmental ways. Adolescents who are struggling to define themselves need understanding and acceptance in addition to the boundaries their parents provide. Mistakes and failures promote growth, and parents can use them as learning opportunities instead of points of criticism. Executives can use active listening provide both the support that their children so desperately need as well as the stability and structure they naturally exude.

- Actively listening to their teens and withholding comments and judgments – especially while their children are speaking – is the first step toward understanding.
- Withholding judgment can be difficult, especially when Executive parents feel they "know what's best." However, taking time to see things from their children's perspective, and remembering how different that view is thanks to their ages and unique personalities, is an incredibly important skill to develop.

Teens who feel accepted for who they are can gain the confidence necessary to face the many challenges their future can undoubtedly hold.

Conclusion

Parenting is one of the most challenging experiences that anyone can face, regardless of their personality type. Executives have unique strengths and weaknesses that they can leverage to build positive, proactive relationships with their children. There's tremendous potential for personal development that takes place when becoming a parent, and Executives can gain a much deeper understanding of themselves and others if they use this opportunity to do so.

The advice provided above is based on general growth stages for children and basic strengths and weaknesses that many Executives share. All children are different, and parents are the best judges of what their children need. The advice above should be used in ways that work best for each family without adding additional stress, frustration, or burden. For special situations, such as behavioral or medical issues, it's best to consult with professionals, such as pediatricians or pediatric psychologists, to come up with plans that can work best for everyone involved.

Final Words

Some Extraverted types like Executives seek a pinnacle position for themselves, and given their drive and capability, it's not unusual for them to earn such status in life. But a high place can be a precipice with unique opportunities and pitfalls; balance is required. One of the most worthy and balanced uses of power is to help others avoid misfortune and act on their own potential. Executives become admirable mentors and protectors when they unconditionally extend their energy and wisdom to others in aid instead of judgment.

Being a positive force takes commitment, and while emotional connections aren't always easy for Executives, they maintain a deep sense of dedication to their beliefs, including responsibility to other people in their lives. Sharing their energetic sense of practical efficiency is more than a personal ethic for these types – it's a form of love. Executives who become facilitators of well-being achieve more than just a high position. They gain genuine respect and appreciation, and a rewarding place in their relationships and communities.

In these pages, we've discussed how Executives can enhance their romantic relationships, friendships, and bonds with their children. Of course, because relationships involve multiple people, no one person can "fix" them on their own – not even if that person is as dedicated as an Executive. Our hope is that, by drawing on the insights in these pages, Executives can take steps to improve their social connections while honoring the values that they hold dear. By examining their relationships – and the sometimes uncomfortable emotions that come with them – Executives can grow in new ways, bolstering the respectable character that they strive to embody.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you better understand and strengthen your relationships? Explore our Relationships Specialized Tests.
- Looking to enhance your academic or professional life? Check out the *Executive Guide to Careers*.
- Ready to build a strong foundation for your self-development? *Our Executive Guide to Personal Growth* may be just what you need.

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